

THE MISUNDERSTOOD ASSEMBLY

Rediscovering What Christ Meant When He Said,

“I Will Build My Ekklesia”

Terry Kashian

Copyright

The Misunderstood Assembly
Copyright © 2026 by Terry Kashian

All rights reserved.

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means—electronic, mechanical, photocopying, recording, or otherwise—without prior written permission of the copyright holder, except for brief quotations used in reviews, articles, teaching, or as otherwise permitted by applicable copyright law.

Scripture quotations are from the author’s own translation and renderings (**TKB**), except where otherwise indicated. Certain renderings may reflect wording common to established English Bible translations.

Published by Kingdom Light Publishers
a publishing imprint and DBA of Integrity Image Enterprise, LLC
Tucson, Arizona, USA

First Edition, 2026

ISBN: _____

Cover design and interior concept: Terry Kashian

Printed in the United States of America

Dedication

**To all who long for an open heaven
and desire to see the visions of God.**

To those who believe there is still more to see—

who are willing to look beyond what has become familiar,
to allow greater light to enlarge their understanding,
and to see the *ekklesia* from God’s point of view.

Ezekiel wrote:

“The heavens were opened, and I saw visions of God.”

— Ezekiel 1:1

May the heavens be opened over our understanding.

May we see Christ more clearly,
His Body more fully,
His House more beautifully,
and His purpose more deeply.

And in His light,
may we see what He has been building all along.

This booklet is dedicated to those who want to see

Introduction

Few words in the Christian vocabulary carry as much history as the word *church*. For many of us, the word immediately brings to mind a building, a congregation, a denomination, a ministry, or a particular form of gathering. These associations are understandable. They have been shaped by centuries of Christian practice and, for many believers, by sincere and meaningful experiences of faith.

This booklet asks the reader to look beneath those familiar associations and return to a more basic question:
What did Christ have in view when He said, “I will build My *ekklesia*”?

That question deserves to be approached with humility. None of us comes to Scripture without a history. We have received teaching from people who loved God, participated in forms of church life that have genuinely helped us, and developed understandings according to the light available to us. Greater light does not require us to despise what came before. It simply asks us to remain teachable when Scripture opens something more clearly.

For that reason, the purpose of these pages is not to criticize denominations, ministries, congregations, or the believers who participate in them. Nor is it to present another model of church that everyone should imitate. The concern is more fundamental. Before asking how Christians should meet, organize, lead, or minister, we need to understand **what Christ is building**.

The New Testament presents a remarkably rich picture. Christ speaks of His *ekklesia*. Peter speaks of living stones being built into a spiritual house. Paul speaks of God’s building, God’s temple, the household of God, and the Body of Christ. He describes believers as members joined to one another, each receiving grace and each contributing according to measure. He speaks of assemblies identifiable in particular cities, of mature believers caring for the flock, of saints being prepared for the work of ministry, and of the whole Body growing through the supply of its members.

These are not disconnected images. Neither should they be collapsed into one another. Each contributes something distinct to our understanding. A **Foundation** is not the same thing as a **ground**. A **Body** emphasizes relationships of life and mutual supply, while a **House** brings stewardship, responsibility, and building into view. Gift is not the same as maturity, and maturity does not eliminate the participation of the other members. Careful attention to these distinctions allows the larger picture to emerge without forcing Scripture into a predetermined system.

This requires a simple interpretive discipline that will appear repeatedly throughout these pages: **words and metaphors must first be understood in their immediate contexts.** A rock in one passage should not automatically be made identical to a rock in another. Foundation, cornerstone, building, house, Body, and ground must each be allowed to say what the biblical writer is using them to say before we bring them together into a larger theological understanding.

As that picture develops, the assembly begins to appear as something profoundly living. Believers are not spectators gathered around the spiritual activity of a few. They are members of Christ, recipients of grace, living stones, brothers and sisters, stewards in God's House, and participants in the building up of His Body. The life within them is intended to find expression through relationships of speaking and serving, receiving and supplying, caring and being cared for.

This also means that the questions raised in this booklet are personal. It is easier to examine structures than to allow revelation to examine us. Yet Christ's building involves both. We must be willing to ask not only what the *church* is, but what our place is within what Christ is building. What have we received? How are we stewarding it? How do we recognize the other members of His Body? How does our common life in Christ become practically expressed where we live?

The chapters that follow move progressively through those questions. We will begin where Jesus began—with revelation and His declaration, **"I will build My *ekklesia*."** From there we will consider the Foundation and the ground, maturity and responsibility, the functioning of the saints when they gather, and finally the larger purpose for which Christ is building a people together.

This booklet, however, does not attempt to explore all the practical implications of the assembly expressed according to locality. The territorial dimension of the city, the relationship of believers throughout that city, the responsibility of leadership toward the city as a whole, and the practical ways the life and culture of the Kingdom might find expression throughout its neighborhoods deserve fuller consideration. I intend to explore those matters in a companion booklet entitled *The Church in Your City*.

The reader is therefore invited to approach these pages neither defensively nor merely academically, but with an open Bible and an open heart. Some conclusions may confirm what you already see. Others may challenge assumptions that have become familiar through years of Christian experience. The important question throughout is not who is right, but **what is right according to the light Scripture gives us.**

If we allow that light to lead us, perhaps we will see something more clearly of the beautiful intention contained in the words with which our study begins:

"I will build My *ekklesia*."

Chapter 1

The Misunderstood Assembly

The Revelation Behind the *Ekklesia*

The first occurrence of *ekklesia* (ἐκκλησία) in the New Testament comes from the lips of Jesus. This fact should govern any attempt to understand the nature of the church. Before turning to later apostolic practice, ecclesiastical history, or even the civic background of the Greek term, we must begin where the New Testament begins: with the revelation given at Caesarea Philippi.

Jesus asked His disciples, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter answered, “You are the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Matt. 16:15–16). Jesus then identified the source of Peter’s understanding:

“Flesh and blood has not revealed this to you, but My Father who is in the heavens.”

— Matthew 16:17

The significance of this exchange lies not merely in the correctness of Peter’s confession but in its source. Peter had received an unveiling. What he now perceived concerning Jesus had not originated in natural reasoning; according to Jesus, the Father had revealed it.

The sequence that follows is important:

“You are the Christ, the Son of the living God.”

“And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My *ekklesia*.”

— Matthew 16:16, 18

Peter first declares who Christ is; Christ then declares who Peter is.

This reciprocal movement suggests a principle that appears elsewhere in Scripture: the true knowledge of who we are proceeds from the knowledge of God. “In Your light we see light” (Ps. 36:9). Peter does not begin with an autonomous search for personal identity. He sees Christ, and in the light of that revelation Christ begins to show Peter who he is in relation to His purpose.

Jesus’ declaration concerning Peter is immediately followed by His first announcement of the *ekklesia*: “**I will build My *ekklesia*.**” Peter’s identity is therefore not disclosed in isolation from Christ’s building purpose. The man who has just confessed the Christ is identified as *Petros*, Peter—a stone—and Christ immediately speaks of a rock and of building.

This context must control our interpretation of the rock.

Context Determines the Metaphor

Because Christ is identified with rock and stone imagery elsewhere in Scripture, it is understandable that the rock of Matthew 16 has often been identified directly with Christ. Paul explicitly says, “the Rock was Christ” (1 Cor. 10:4), and Peter later describes Christ as the Living Stone (1 Pet. 2:4).

Yet biblical metaphors do not carry an identical meaning in every passage. Their meaning must first be determined by their immediate context.

Jesus Himself demonstrates this principle in Matthew 7:24–27. Two men hear His words. The wise man hears and does what Jesus says and is compared to a man who builds his house upon rock. The foolish man hears the same words but does not do them and is compared to a man who builds upon sand.

The difference is not hearing; both men hear. The difference is what they do with what they have heard.

In that parable, therefore, the rock is associated with obedience to Christ's words, while the sand is associated with hearing without obedience. The storm reveals the consequence. The house built upon rock does not fall.

The point is important for our interpretation: **rock imagery must be understood according to the context in which it appears.** Paul can explicitly say, “the Rock was Christ,” while Jesus can employ rock imagery in Matthew 7 in connection with hearing and doing His words. Context determines the metaphor. **A biblical image must first be allowed to speak within its own context before its meaning is carried into another passage.**

The same discipline should govern Matthew 16.

Revelation Opens Our Seeing

Immediately before Jesus speaks of the rock, He emphasizes revelation. Peter has confessed Jesus as “the Christ, the Son of the living God,” and Jesus responds that flesh and blood did not reveal this to him; His Father in the heavens did.

The **object of the revelation is Christ.** Peter has been enabled to see something concerning Jesus that natural perception alone had not disclosed.

Revelation works in this way: **it adjusts our seeing and opens us to spiritual reality.**

Paul develops this principle in 1 Corinthians 2. “The Spirit searches all things, yes, the deep things of God” (v. 10). He then explains that just as the spirit of a man knows the things of the man, “no one knows the things of God except the Spirit of God” (v. 11). Believers have received the Spirit who is from God “that we might know the things that have been freely given to us by God” (v. 12).

Revelation therefore brings into view something that cannot be reached merely by natural observation. It opens us to what originates in God.

Yet Peter's experience also teaches us that genuine revelation does not mean complete understanding.

Only a few verses after his confession, Jesus begins to show His disciples that He must go to Jerusalem, suffer, be killed, and be raised again. Peter takes Him aside and rebukes Him. Jesus responds:

"You are not mindful of the things of God, but the things of men."

— Matthew 16:23

The contrast is striking.

Peter has genuinely received something from the Father, yet he does not understand the Father's purpose concerning the Christ whom he has just confessed. He sees that Jesus is the Christ, but he does not yet see clearly what the mission of the Christ requires.

The revelation was genuine. Peter's understanding of its implications was still immature.

Nathanael provides a similar example. When Jesus tells him that He had seen him under the fig tree, Nathanael responds:

"Rabbi, You are the Son of God! You are the King of Israel!"

Jesus does not reject his confession. Instead He tells him:

"You will see greater things than these."

— John 1:49–50

True seeing can be followed by greater seeing.

Revelation may begin with what seems only a sliver of light, yet that light opens a realm in which further understanding becomes possible. We begin to see something from God's side, and as that seeing enlarges, our understanding is increasingly adjusted to His thought and purpose.

This helps us understand the rock in Matthew 16 without requiring Peter himself to have become immediately immovable. Peter was plainly not yet a stable man in every respect. What the Father had unveiled, however, did not derive its reliability from Peter's maturity.

The rock points to the divinely revealed reality Peter has just received: the revelation of Jesus as the Christ, the Son of the living God—a reality originating in the Father rather than in flesh and blood.

“You Are Peter”

The unveiling does not stop with Peter seeing Christ.

Peter says:

“You are the Christ.”

Jesus responds:

“And I also say to you that you are Peter.”

There is a second movement of revelation.

Peter sees something concerning Christ, and in that light Christ reveals something concerning Peter. **“In Your light we see light.”**

Jesus identifies him as a stone in immediate connection with His building purpose.

But once again, being shown something does not mean Peter immediately comprehends its fullness. There is no indication in Matthew 16 that Peter already understands the significance of being a stone in the building Christ is announcing. Indeed, the events that follow demonstrate how much Peter still has to learn concerning both Christ and God’s purpose in Christ.

Years later, however, Peter will write:

“Coming to Him as to a living stone, rejected indeed by men, but chosen by God and precious, you also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house.”

— 1 Peter 2:4–5

The man whom Jesus had called a stone now speaks of Christ as the **Living Stone**, believers as **living stones**, and those stones being **built together into a spiritual house**.

Peter’s understanding has grown.

Earlier in the same letter, Peter speaks of believers having been begotten again “to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead” (1 Pet. 1:3)

and of having been “born again, not of corruptible seed but incorruptible” (1:23). The stones are living because divine life has been imparted to them.

But living stones are not the completed purpose.

They are **being built**.

Regeneration gives life to the material; building brings that living material into God’s corporate purpose. A collection of living stones, however precious each stone may be, is not yet a house.

Peter also uses the unusual word *logikos* in this immediate context when he speaks of the “pure *logikos* milk” (1 Pet. 2:2). The word does not lexically mean “God’s logic,” and we should not claim that it does. Yet its association with reason and the *logos* word-family permits a suggestive theological observation. Pure milk comes from life; formula is manufactured. In the same way, there is a divine logic that proceeds from the Life God supplies and a human logic that can manufacture substitutes for it. The Peter who once received genuine revelation while still reasoning according to “the things of men” eventually came to understand something of the divine logic of God’s building: Christ the Living Stone, believers as living stones, and those stones being built together into a spiritual house.

What Jesus disclosed at Caesarea Philippi had grown in Peter’s understanding.

The building begins with seeing, but our seeing must grow.

We see Christ more fully, and in His light we increasingly understand who we are in relation to His purpose.

Matthew 16 and Paul’s Foundation

At this point an important distinction must be maintained.

Paul writes in 1 Corinthians chapter 3.

“According to the grace of God which was given to me, as a wise master builder I have laid the foundation, and another builds on it. But let each one take heed how he builds on it. For no other foundation can anyone lay than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:10–11

Paul’s language is so close to the building language of Matthew 16 that the two passages can easily be merged. Jesus says, “upon this rock I will build My

ekklesia.” Paul says that Christ is the Foundation and others build upon Him. It is therefore understandable to conclude that the rock in Matthew 16 must also be Christ.

The difficulty is not with the conclusion that Christ is foundational to everything God builds. He unquestionably is. The difficulty arises when the meaning Paul explicitly assigns to **foundation** in one architectural metaphor is imported into Matthew to determine beforehand what Jesus means by **rock** in another.

The two passages are part of the same larger revelation of God’s building, but they need not assign identical meanings to every architectural element. **Each passage must first be allowed to define its own imagery before the two are brought together into a larger theological picture.**

In 1 Corinthians 3, Paul tells us explicitly what the Foundation is: **Jesus Christ**. That statement should retain its full force.

Matthew 16 presents another emphasis. The immediate context is revelation: the Father unveils Christ to Peter; Christ then discloses Peter’s identity as a stone; and in that setting Jesus announces, “upon this rock I will build My *ekklesia*.”

The passages therefore complement one another without needing to be collapsed into one metaphor.

Christ is the Foundation in Paul’s architectural language. In Matthew 16, Christ is the object of the Father’s revelation, and that divine unveiling opens the spiritual reality in which Christ begins His building.

Peter’s own later description of Jesus as the **Living Stone** is helpful here. Stone imagery itself is not restricted to one fixed referent. Christ is the Living Stone; believers are living stones; Paul can call Christ the Foundation; Revelation can speak of twelve foundations bearing the names of the apostles. Scripture allows architectural imagery to serve different purposes according to context.

What remains constant is Christ’s indispensable and determinative place in the entire building.

From Stone to Building

The thread running from Jesus’ declaration to the apostolic writings is not merely stone imagery but **building**.

Jesus says:

“I will build My *ekklesia*.”

Peter later speaks of living stones “being built up” into a spiritual house (1 Pet. 2:5).

Paul tells the Corinthians:

“You are God’s building.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:9

A few verses later he writes:

“Do you not know that you are the temple of God and that the Spirit of God dwells in you?”

— 1 Corinthians 3:16

The pronouns are plural. Paul is addressing the Corinthian believers corporately. God’s building is therefore not merely a metaphor for individual spiritual development. The saints together constitute God’s sanctuary.

Ephesians develops the same corporate purpose through another architectural perspective. Believers are no longer “strangers and foreigners,” but “fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God” (Eph. 2:19). They have been built upon “the foundation of the apostles and prophets,” with Christ Jesus Himself as the cornerstone (2:20).

There is no contradiction between this passage and 1 Corinthians 3:11. Architectural metaphors need not assign every component the same referent in every passage. In 1 Corinthians 3, Christ is the one Foundation upon whom Paul builds. In Ephesians 2, apostolic and prophetic ministry is described as foundational, while Christ occupies the unique position of cornerstone by whom the structure is ordered.

The same flexibility appears in Revelation 21, where the New Jerusalem has twelve foundations bearing “the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb” (Rev. 21:14).

Again, context determines the metaphor.

Ephesians then brings us to the purpose of the building:

“In whom the whole building, being fitted together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord, in whom you also are being built together into a dwelling place of God in spirit.”

— Ephesians 2:21–22

The movement is from “the whole building” to “**you also are being built together.**” What is universally true of God’s building becomes concrete among the people who constitute it.

The purpose is habitation.

God is not merely gathering redeemed individuals. He is building a corporate dwelling for Himself.

The Building and the Body

The architectural imagery of the New Testament eventually converges with another major metaphor: the Body of Christ.

Again, Corinth provides particularly important evidence.

Paul begins his letter by addressing:

“The *ekklesia* of God which is at Corinth.”

— 1 Corinthians 1:2

Later he tells these same believers:

“You are God’s building.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:9

And:

“You are the temple of God.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:16

Then:

“Now you are the Body of Christ, and members individually.”

— 1 Corinthians 12:27

Paul is not describing unrelated spiritual realities. Building, temple, and Body illuminate different aspects of the same corporate people.

The building emphasizes construction and fitting together. The temple emphasizes God's dwelling and holiness. The Body emphasizes organic life, mutual dependence, and union with Christ.

Paul makes an especially striking statement in 1 Corinthians 12:12:

“For as the body is one and has many members, but all the members of that one body, being many, are one body, so also is Christ.”

One might have expected Paul to conclude, “so also is the church.” Instead he writes, **“so also is Christ.”**

This does not erase the distinction between Christ and His people. It demonstrates the organic nature of their union with Him. The Head cannot be separated conceptually from the members through whom His life receives corporate expression.

Consequently, when Paul tells the Corinthians, “You are the Body of Christ,” he does not imply that the believers in Corinth exhaust the universal Body or constitute another Body separate from believers elsewhere. Rather, the one Body is genuinely expressed among them.

A person standing on the coast in San Diego can look upon the Pacific Ocean, while another standing near Seattle can look upon that same ocean. The cities do not create separate Pacific Oceans, nor does the ocean become divided because it is encountered from different locations. Each locality simply provides a distinct place from which the same body of water is encountered.

In the same way, the Body of Christ remains one wherever it is expressed. **The place of its expression does not divide the Body; it identifies where the one Body becomes locally visible.**

This distinction will become especially important when we consider the practical ground of the assembly.

“Is Christ Divided?”

This makes Paul's opening correction of the Corinthians considerably more serious than a disagreement over preferred ministers.

Paul had learned that factions were developing among them. Some were saying, “I am of Paul,” others, “I am of Apollos,” others, “I am of Cephas,” and still others, “I am of Christ” (1 Cor. 1:12).

Paul responds:

“Is Christ divided?”

— 1 Corinthians 1:13

The force of the question should not be softened.

Paul does not begin by asking whether their organization has been divided. He reaches beneath the organizational manifestation to the spiritual contradiction underneath it: **the Christ whose life constitutes His Body cannot be partitioned according to human allegiance.**

Paul returns to the problem in chapter 3:

“For when one says, ‘I am of Paul,’ and another, ‘I am of Apollos,’ are you not carnal?”

— 1 Corinthians 3:4

Paul and Apollos themselves are not the problem. They are servants through whom the Corinthians believed. One planted, another watered, but God gave the growth (3:5–6).

The problem begins when legitimate ministries become competing identities.

Paul eventually reverses their reasoning:

“Let no one boast in men. For all things are yours: whether Paul or Apollos or Cephas ... all are yours. And you are Christ’s, and Christ is God’s.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:21–23

The Corinthians had been identifying themselves according to particular ministers. Paul turns the relationship around. **The saints are not the possession of Paul, Apollos, or Cephas; these servants have been given for the benefit of the saints.**

The saints belong to Christ.

Gifted ministries may serve the *ekklesia*, teach it, equip it, and care for it, but they do not possess it.

Jesus did not say, “I will build their *ekklesia*.”

He said:

“I will build My *ekklesia*.”

The Builder establishes the ownership.

Why *Ekklesia*?

Only after recognizing the revelatory and building context of Matthew 16 are we prepared to ask what Jesus’ choice of the word *ekklesia* contributes to His declaration.

The term was not invented by Christianity. In classical Greek usage, *ekklesia* could designate an assembly, particularly an assembly of citizens in the civic life of a Greek *polis*. The related vocabulary was used for assembling and deliberating together.

But the civic background is only one part of the word’s history.

Ekklesia was also well established in the Greek Scriptures as a term for the assembled people of Israel. This background remains visible within the New Testament itself. Speaking of Israel at Sinai, Stephen refers to Moses as being:

“in the *ekklesia* in the wilderness.”

— Acts 7:38

The KJV famously renders the phrase “the church in the wilderness,” but the Greek is *en tē ekklēsia en tē erēmō*—the assembly in the wilderness.

Stephen is not suggesting that Israel in the wilderness was identical to the New Testament *ekklesia*. His language establishes a more basic point: ***ekklesia* was already biblical vocabulary for an assembled people long before it became the customary designation for assemblies of believers in Christ.**

This prevents us from reducing the term either to a Greek political institution or to a uniquely Christian religious word.

Acts 19 provides unusually clear confirmation from the civic side. During the disturbance at Ephesus, Luke uses *ekklesia* three times for gatherings that are

certainly not Christian assemblies. The confused gathering is called an *ekklesia* in verse 32; the city clerk refers to a “lawful *ekklesia*” in verse 39; and after his speech he dismisses the *ekklesia* in verse 41.

Luke’s usage demonstrates from within the New Testament that the word had not become an exclusively religious technical term. Its basic reference remained an assembly of people.

At the same time, Israel’s scriptural history prevents us from treating the civic usage as though it alone determines Jesus’ meaning. Both streams belong to the linguistic background: *ekklesia* was recognizable assembly language in Greek civic life and had an established history in the Greek Scriptures for the assembled people of God.

Jesus takes this familiar word and makes an extraordinary claim upon it:

“My *ekklesia*.”

The decisive theological significance does not come from discovering a hidden meaning in the etymology of the word. It comes from the One who claims the assembly as His own and declares that He Himself will build it.

“I Will Build My *Ekklesia*”

We can now return to Jesus’ declaration with greater clarity.

The Father unveils Christ. In the light of Christ, Peter is shown something of his own identity as a stone. Christ announces His intention to build. **The life that makes the stones living comes from Him, and the resulting corporate people are His.**

This is why Paul’s question, **“Is Christ divided?”**, reaches to the heart of the matter.

The *ekklesia* cannot finally be understood by beginning with structures, traditions, ministries, institutions, or historical forms. It must be understood from Christ—whose life constitutes it, whose people compose it, and whose building it is.

What Christ is building belongs to Him and derives its life from Him.

The Building Completed

The final book of Scripture brings the building imagery to an extraordinary consummation.

John is shown “the Bride, the Lamb’s wife” (Rev. 21:9), but what he sees is “the great city, the holy Jerusalem” (21:10). The Bride is portrayed as a corporate city filled with the glory of God.

The wall of the city has twelve foundations bearing “the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb” (21:14). Those foundations are adorned with precious stones (21:19–20). The city itself is characterized by gold, precious stones, divine light, and the presence of God and the Lamb.

The imagery should not be flattened into a single architectural formula. Revelation is portraying the consummation of a corporate people through the symbolism of a bride and a city. Yet the continuity of the biblical building theme is difficult to miss.

The canonical trajectory is striking. Jesus identifies Peter as a stone and announces His intention to build His *ekklesia* (Matt. 16:16–18). Peter later describes Christ as the Living Stone and believers as living stones being built into a spiritual house (1 Pet. 2:4–5). Paul describes believers as “God’s building” and “the temple of God” (1 Cor. 3:9, 16). Ephesians describes the whole building growing into a holy temple and believers being built together into a dwelling place of God in spirit (Eph. 2:21–22). Hebrews directs our attention to the city whose Builder and Maker is God (Heb. 11:10). Finally, John sees the Bride as the holy city Jerusalem, whose foundations bear the names of the apostles of the Lamb and are adorned with precious stones (Rev. 21:9–10, 14, 19–20).

Scripture does not state this progression as a single formula, and we should not pretend that it does. Yet the continuity of the imagery permits a coherent theological synthesis.

Divine life produces living material. Living material is built together into God’s habitation. The completed building displays the precious character and glory of God.

Peter himself stands within that trajectory.

The man whom Jesus called Peter—a stone—in connection with His announced building eventually became the apostle who described Christ as the Living Stone and believers as living stones being built into a spiritual house. In John’s final vision, Peter is necessarily included among “the twelve apostles of the Lamb” whose names appear upon the foundations of the consummated city.

What began for Peter as revelation continued to enlarge.

He saw Christ.

In Christ's light he was shown something of himself.

And with greater light he came to understand that being a stone was never merely about Peter.

It was about the building.

“I will build My *ekklesia*.”

To understand the *ekklesia*, then, we must first see Christ. In His light we begin to see who we are. As that revelation grows, we discover that our calling is not merely to exist as individually redeemed people, but to become living material built together for the corporate expression and habitation of God.

The question is therefore not first whether our present forms are traditional, successful, familiar, or effective.

The prior question is simpler and more searching:

Do they correspond to what Christ said He is building?

Chapter 2

The Foundation and the Ground

Chapter One brought us to Jesus' declaration at Caesarea Philippi: **“I will build My *ekklesia*.”** The revelation is of Christ, the living material receives its life from Christ, and the building is His. Yet once we recognize that Christ is building a people rather than merely gathering isolated believers, another question naturally arises:

Upon what basis are those believers built together and recognized as an assembly in a particular place?

The New Testament gives an unequivocal answer concerning the Foundation. Paul writes to the Corinthians:

“According to the grace of God which was given to me, as a wise master builder I have laid the foundation, and another builds on it. But let each one take heed how he builds on it. For no other foundation can anyone lay than that which is laid, which is Jesus Christ.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:10–11

Paul describes himself as a *sophos architektōn*—a wise or skilled master builder. Whatever else may be said about God’s building, Paul leaves no uncertainty concerning the Foundation upon which he builds:

Jesus Christ.

This distinction must remain clear throughout everything that follows. The Foundation is not a doctrine about Christ, an apostolic method, a particular ministry, a locality, or a form of church government. In the architectural perspective Paul employs here, the Foundation is Christ Himself.

But recognizing the Foundation raises another question. A foundation is laid somewhere. If Christ is the Foundation, how does that Foundation become real in the believer, and how do believers who possess that same Christ stand together corporately?

Here we must distinguish two closely related matters without blending them: Foundation and ground. The Foundation has individual and corporate dimensions, while the ground has spiritual and practical sides. They are not the same thing.

The Foundation is Christ. Individually, Christ is received within the believer and becomes the inward basis of salvation, stability, and spiritual formation. Corporately, those who possess the same Christ stand together upon Him as the one Foundation of God’s building.

The ground answers another question. The New Testament does not explicitly use *ground* as a technical ecclesiological term for the basis upon which believers gather, so we will use the term descriptively rather than claim it as Paul’s terminology. The ground has an inward, spiritual side in the human spirit and an outward, practical side in locality. Spiritually, the believer stands in the place where he has been joined to the Lord. Practically, believers who possess that same Christ stand together in the city where they live.

There is therefore one Foundation: Christ. The question that remains is what legitimate practical ground the New Testament recognizes for those founded upon Christ to stand together.

A word of clarification is necessary because some English translations of 1 Timothy 3:15 describe the assembly of the living God as “the pillar and ground of the truth.” There the word translated *ground* is *hedraiōma*, carrying the thought of support, stay, or buttress. Paul is describing the relationship of the assembly to the truth: the House bears and supports it. He is not discussing the ground upon which believers take their corporate stand.

As we saw with *rock* and *foundation* in Chapter One, **a biblical image or architectural term must first be allowed to function within its own context before its meaning is carried into another passage.**

Christ is the Foundation upon whom we are built. The ground identifies where our standing upon that Foundation becomes real—spiritually within and practically together.

The first question before us is therefore practical:

What practical boundary did the apostles recognize when identifying the assembly of believers in a particular place?

A Pattern Begins to Emerge

The opening of 1 Corinthians provides an important clue.

Paul does not write to an assembly identified by Paul, Apollos, or Cephas. Nor does he identify the believers according to a particular emphasis, practice, or spiritual experience. He writes:

“To the ekklesia of God which is in Corinth.”

— 1 Corinthians 1:2

The designation is remarkably simple.

It is **God’s ekklesia**, and it is **in Corinth**.

Ownership is determined by God; location identifies where that assembly is found.

This pattern extends beyond Corinth. Paul writes to “the saints who are in Ephesus” (Eph. 1:1), to “all the saints in Christ Jesus who are in Philippi” (Phil. 1:1), and to “the ekklesia of the Thessalonians” (1 Thess. 1:1). Jerusalem likewise becomes recognizable as a place in which the ekklesia has concrete existence (Acts 8:1; 11:22).

The opening chapters of Revelation make the pattern even more visible. John writes to seven *ekklesiai* in Asia, and each is identified according to a city: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea (Rev. 1:11).

Seven cities. Seven identifiable local expressions.

Nothing in these passages by itself establishes a complete doctrine of locality. But taken together, they reveal a consistent apostolic practice: **believers are repeatedly identified according to the place in which they live and assemble.**

This becomes particularly significant in Paul's instructions to Titus.

City by City

Paul had left Titus in Crete with unfinished work:

“For this reason I left you in Crete, that you should set in order the things that are lacking, and appoint elders in every city as I commanded you.”

— Titus 1:5

The expression translated “in every city” is *kata polin*—city by city.

Crete was the larger geographical region, but the appointment of elders was carried out according to the cities within it. Paul does not describe eldership here as extending over all Crete under a single local eldership, nor does this passage describe multiple competing elderships within the same city. The organizational pattern actually stated in the text is simpler: **elders were to be appointed city by city.**

This evidence allows us to speak of locality as the **practical side of the ground** of the local assembly. Again, *ground* is our descriptive term, not Paul's. The biblical observation underneath it is that the New Testament repeatedly recognizes believers corporately according to locality.

This distinction helps prevent us from confusing **Foundation** with **ground**.

Christ is not the Foundation because believers happen to live in the same city. Neither is the city a second foundation alongside Christ.

Christ is the Foundation.

The locality is the legitimate practical ground.

The believers in Corinth were not built upon Corinth. They were built upon Christ. Yet the one building of God had a recognizable expression **in Corinth.**

The Foundation tells us **upon whom we stand.** The ground tells us **where that standing is realized.** The distinction is fine, but essential. If locality becomes the Foundation, something belonging only to Christ has been given to geography. If

Christ as Foundation is used to erase the question of ground altogether, we are left without an answer to how the one Body becomes practically recognizable among believers living in the same place.

This takes us back to something Paul had already confronted among those very believers.

“I Am of Paul”

Chapter One considered Paul’s correction of those who were saying, “I am of Paul,” “I am of Apollos,” and “I am of Cephas,” and his searching question, “Is Christ divided?” (1 Cor. 1:12–13). Here that correction takes on another significance. If the believers in Corinth could not legitimately derive separate identities from the servants who ministered to them, what did they share that preceded all such distinctions?

They were Christ’s, and they were together **in Corinth**.

Their common life came from Christ. Their common location was Corinth. Neither a favored minister nor a particular emphasis needed to provide an additional identity.

This gives locality an important but limited function. **The city does not produce the unity of the Body; Christ does.** Geography cannot create spiritual oneness. It provides the practical boundary within which those who are already Christ’s encounter one another and learn to stand together as His one Body.

We do not become one by standing on the same ground. **We stand together on the same ground because in Christ we are already one.**

One Body, Expressed in a Place

Chapter One established the distinction between the universal Body and its local expression. The Corinthians were not another Body of Christ, nor did they exhaust the universal Body. Yet Paul could say to them, “Now you are the Body of Christ” (1 Cor. 12:27). The one Body had become concretely expressible among believers living together in Corinth.

That earlier conclusion now helps us see the function of locality more precisely: **locality does not divide the universal Body; it identifies the place in which the one Body becomes locally visible.** Corinth, Ephesus, Philippi, and Thessalonica did not possess different Bodies of Christ. There is one Body, yet that Body necessarily becomes visible somewhere.

The universal must become local if it is to become practical.

But locality alone cannot produce the building. The people of God may occupy the same city and remain little more than individual stones lying near one another. Something inward must correspond to the outward standing.

The Spiritual Side of the Ground

Paul writes:

“In whom the whole building, being fitted together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord, in whom you also are being built together into a dwelling place of God in spirit.”

— Ephesians 2:21–22

The purpose is not merely that Christians occupying the same geographical area recognize one another. People can share a city without sharing life, and they can share an address without being built together.

God’s purpose is habitation.

The expression “being built together” moves beyond proximity. It speaks of relationship, fitting, and corporate formation. The believers are not merely located near one another; in Christ they are being constituted together as a dwelling place of God.

Paul elsewhere describes the believer’s union with the Lord in striking terms:

“He who is joined to the Lord is one spirit with Him.”

— 1 Corinthians 6:17

Here we encounter the spiritual side of the ground. The human spirit is the inward place in which the believer is joined to the Lord and participates in the spiritual reality from which the building proceeds. Locality gives the outward boundary of the corporate standing; the human spirit gives its inward spiritual reality.

At the same time, the human spirit must never be confused with the Foundation. **Christ is the Foundation present within the believer; the human spirit is where that inward union with Him is realized.**

This is where the two matters can easily be blended, so the distinction deserves care.

The **Foundation** has an individual and corporate dimension. Individually, Christ is received and experienced within the believer, bringing salvation and progressively producing stability. Corporately, that same Christ becomes the common Foundation upon whom the saints stand and are built together.

The **ground** also has two related sides. Spiritually, that standing is realized in the human spirit where the believer is joined to the Lord. Practically, it is expressed in the locality where believers possessing the same Christ stand together.

One Foundation: Christ

One legitimate ground: spiritually realized in the human spirit and practically expressed in the locality.

From Stability to Building

The individual side of the Foundation is essential because unstable material is difficult to build with. Christ does not merely save us from something; His life begins forming something within us.

Peter provides a remarkable illustration. At Caesarea Philippi he is identified as a stone in relation to Christ's announced building, yet the events that follow show that Peter still requires considerable formation. His revelation is genuine, but his understanding, reactions, and stability must grow through experience.

Christ as Foundation works inwardly until what was once easily moved becomes increasingly stable, established, and **buildable**.

Yet the New Testament does not present this individual development as an independent spiritual project. The individual side exists in relationship to the corporate side. God is not merely producing stable stones. He is building a House.

This becomes particularly clear when the New Testament speaks about growth.

Growth in the Context of the Body

Peter writes:

“As newborn babes, desire the pure *logikos* milk, that you may grow thereby.”

— 1 Peter 2:2

The image itself is revealing. A newborn is not self-sufficient. Its very life assumes nourishment received through relationship. The child does not first grow

independently and then become part of a family. The child is born into a relationship of life and receives nourishment there.

Peter's thought immediately moves from newborn babes and milk to Christ the Living Stone and believers as living stones:

“Coming to Him as to a living stone...you also, as living stones, are being built up a spiritual house.”

— 1 Peter 2:4–5

The movement is striking: **newborn life, nourishment, growth, Living Stone, living stones, spiritual House.**

Peter does not picture the believer growing in isolation until sufficiently mature to become part of the building. Growth occurs in the very context of the life that is bringing the stones together.

Paul uses similar imagery when addressing Corinth:

“I...spoke to you as to fleshly, as to babes in Christ. I fed you with milk and not with solid food.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:1–2

The evidence that they remained babes appears immediately in their relationships. Paul points to envy, strife, and their party declarations: “I am of Paul” and “I am of Apollos” (3:3–4).

Their immaturity was not merely a private deficiency hidden somewhere inside the individual believer. **It became visible in their inability to live properly with one another.**

This is significant. Paul does not measure maturity merely by how much revelation someone can articulate, how much Scripture has been learned, or how many spiritual experiences have been accumulated. The Corinthians were gifted, yet their relationships exposed their lack of development.

Growth, therefore, is not preparation for Body life.

Growth takes place in the context of Body life.

The newborn does not mature somewhere apart from the family and return later as a fully developed son or daughter. Neither does the living stone mature independently and then report for construction. Stability, fitting, relationship,

function, correction, nourishment, and growth take place as the saints are joined to Christ and increasingly built with one another.

The Mother and Her Nourishment

The newborn imagery allows us to see another beautiful corporate relationship.

Paul speaks in Galatians of “the Jerusalem above” as “**the mother of us all**” (Gal. 4:26). Peter does not explicitly identify the mother in his newborn imagery, and we should not make him say what he does not say. Yet when these New Testament pictures are placed beside one another, a significant practical truth emerges: **God has not designed His children to nourish themselves independently of the corporate life into which they have been brought.**

A newborn needs milk, and milk belongs naturally to the relationship between mother and child.

Peter calls this nourishment *logikos* milk. The word does not lexically mean *faith and love*, nor should it be made to do so. But its connection with what is rational or corresponding to *logos* permits a practical theological application. The logic of divine life is profoundly different from the logic of self-sufficiency.

Two qualities appear repeatedly throughout the New Testament as governing expressions of this life: **faith and love.**

We live by faith.

We walk in love.

Figuratively speaking, these may be seen as the two breasts of the corporate mother through which the newborn life is nourished. This is not a lexical definition of Peter’s *logikos* milk, but a practical picture drawn from the broader New Testament testimony.

Faith turns continually toward Christ as the Source. Love carries what has been received into relationship with the other members.

Faith receives from Christ; love communicates His life within the Body.

Paul repeatedly joins the two. He hears of the Ephesians’ “faith in the Lord Jesus and love for all the saints” (Eph. 1:15). He speaks of “faith working through love” (Gal. 5:6). And when Ephesians eventually describes the maturity of the Body, the whole process culminates in the Body making its growth “to the building up of itself in love” (Eph. 4:16).

The nourishment of the newborn is therefore not merely for private enrichment. The life received by faith develops within relationships governed by love.

The Body Is the Environment of Growth

Ephesians brings these threads together with unusual clarity.

Paul describes believers no longer remaining children, but “speaking the truth in love” and growing up into Christ the Head. He then immediately describes the whole Body as joined and fitted together, every joint supplying and every part operating according to its measure, “making the growth of the body to the building up of itself in love” (Eph. 4:15–16).

Growth is not happening beside the Body.

The Body itself is growing, and its members grow within that corporate life.

This helps us understand the relationship between the individual and corporate sides of the Foundation. Individually, Christ establishes us, makes us increasingly stable, and forms us into material suitable for His purpose. Corporately, those same believers stand upon Christ together, where their relationships become the environment in which they function, receive, supply, adjust, and mature.

Individually, the Foundation makes us buildable. Corporately, the Foundation makes building possible.

And the ground provides the sphere in which that corporate reality can take practical form.

The city gathers no spiritual power merely because it is a city. The human spirit possesses no independent virtue apart from the Christ who dwells there. What matters is that those possessing Christ inwardly recognize one another and take their stand together upon Him in the place where God has set them.

This is why the individual and corporate cannot finally be separated. A believer may possess genuine life and genuine experience of Christ, but God's intention is not a collection of independently mature Christians.

God does not mature stones merely to produce better stones. He matures them in the building.

When Other Identities Become the Ground

At this point a more searching question arises.

If the New Testament repeatedly identifies assemblies according to locality, and if Paul resists the formation of identities around even legitimate ministers, what happens when believers living in the same place begin defining themselves principally by something else?

The question deserves care.

Christians may differ in understanding, practice, history, culture, gifting, and spiritual experience. Some differences are substantial and should not be trivialized. Nor does the New Testament picture of unity require the disappearance of every distinction among believers.

Recognizing one another as family does not require pretending that every note is in tune. Believers can be genuinely joined to Christ and still carry immature understandings, mistaken ideas, and practices that require adjustment. Love does not call the wrong note right, but neither does it make every wrong note a reason to stop playing together. The New Testament joins truth and love. We are to speak the truth in love precisely because growth is still taking place within the relationships of the Body.

This is one reason the ground matters. If agreement upon every point becomes the condition of our standing together, maturity has effectively become a prerequisite for family rather than something developed within it. But family precedes maturity. Children are born into a family and learn, adjust, and grow within its relationships. In the same way, those who share the Life of Christ must learn to recognize one another as brothers and sisters while that Life progressively brings their understanding, relationships, and conduct into harmony with Him.

The issue is more fundamental:

Can something given to only part of the Body become the basis upon which that part separates its identity from the rest of the Body?

A gifted teacher may greatly enrich the saints. A particular truth may recover something neglected. A spiritual experience may profoundly affect a community. A form of worship may help believers express genuine devotion.

The difficulty begins when what was given to **serve the Body** becomes what **defines a separate body**.

This is why Paul's treatment of Apollos is so instructive. Apollos was not the problem. Paul was not the problem. Cephas was not the problem.

“I am of” was the problem.

The gift had become an identity.

A gift may be entirely legitimate while its use as a ground of separation is not.

And once a secondary identity becomes the practical basis of separation, the question Paul asked Corinth returns with uncomfortable relevance:

“Is Christ divided?”

Foundation Without Rival

We can now state the distinction more carefully.

There is only one Foundation:

Jesus Christ.

Individually, He is received within the believer, where His life becomes salvation, experience, stability, and formation. Corporately, those possessing that same Christ stand together upon Him as the common Foundation of the building.

There is also one legitimate ground upon which this corporate standing becomes practical. Its spiritual reality is in the human spirit, where the believer is joined to the Lord; its outward expression is the locality in which believers stand together.

The New Testament repeatedly shows this practical expression according to place—Corinth, Ephesus, Philippi, Thessalonica, Jerusalem, and the cities addressed in Revelation. Titus 1:5 further demonstrates a city-by-city pattern of local oversight.

The distinction can therefore be stated simply without collapsing its parts:

One Foundation — Christ.

One legitimate ground — spiritually realized in the human spirit and practically expressed in locality.

One Body — possessing the same Christ and learning to stand, function, and grow together.

The city does not make believers one.

Christ has already done something far deeper.

Nor does the individual believer grow into this oneness as though it were a later stage of spiritual development. The saints begin with one Life and are called to grow within the relationships created by that Life.

The practical question is whether those who are already His will allow something less than Christ to become the identity that separates them from one another.

Perhaps, then, the question confronting us is not first:

“Which church is mine?”

The more fundamental questions may be:

Whose am I?

And:

How should our common life in Christ be expressed among His people where I live?

Chapter 3

The Order of the Assembly

Maturity, Gift, and Responsibility

Chapter Two brought us to Paul’s instruction that elders were to be appointed *kata polin*—city by city (Titus 1:5). Once the *ekklesia* has a recognizable expression in a locality, another question naturally follows: **How was that assembly cared for, ordered, built, and served?**

The New Testament does not answer by giving us a hierarchy of religious titles. Instead, as the record unfolds, we find mature believers entrusted with responsibility, gifted people serving the saints, and ministries whose spheres may extend beyond a single locality. These functions are distinct, yet they operate within one life under the direction of the Holy Spirit.

Chapter Two also established something essential for what follows. Spiritual growth does not occur as an isolated process that eventually leads a believer into Body life. **Growth takes place in the context of the Body.** The Body provides relationships of nourishment and mutual supply, while the House provides the

context in which what God has entrusted to each member can be faithfully stewarded. Order creates an environment in which living members can grow, function, supply, receive, and increasingly become skillful in building one another. Perhaps nowhere is the simplicity of this order more clearly displayed than in the opening words of Philippians.

An Established Assembly at Philippi

Paul writes:

“Paul and Timothy, bondservants of Jesus Christ, to all the saints in Christ Jesus who are in Philippi, with the overseers and deacons.”

— Philippians 1:1

The order is significant. Paul and Timothy identify themselves as slaves of Christ Jesus. Whatever authority or gifting they possess, they begin with servanthood. Paul then addresses all the saints in Philippi, followed by the overseers and deacons who function among them.

Philippians is unique among Paul’s letters in opening with this explicit address to the saints together with overseers and deacons. It provides a remarkably compact picture of an established local assembly. The saints are not introduced as an audience gathered around a ministry. **They are the assembly.** Among them are people carrying recognized oversight and others rendering recognized service.

The word “**with**” is important. The overseers and deacons are distinguished because of their responsibilities, but they remain with the saints. Paul’s greeting gives recognition to function without creating a separate spiritual class.

Corinth provides a revealing contrast.

Gift and Maturity

Few assemblies in the New Testament appear more richly gifted than Corinth. Paul tells them that they “come short in no gift” (1 Cor. 1:7). Yet only a short time later he says, “I could not speak to you as to spiritual people but as to fleshly, as to babes in Christ” (1 Cor. 3:1).

Gift was abundant; maturity was not.

This distinction is essential to understanding order in the *ekklesia*. Spiritual gifting provides capacity for service, but gifting itself does not demonstrate the maturity necessary to carry responsibility for others. Corinth makes that

distinction particularly clear because the same believers who lacked no gift could still be described by Paul as babes.

Their immaturity also appeared corporately. Jealousy, strife, party identities, disputes among brothers, disorder surrounding the Lord's supper, and the misuse of spiritual manifestations were not unrelated defects. They revealed believers who possessed genuine spiritual capacity but had not yet learned to use what they possessed effectively for the good of the whole.

Spiritual gifts may therefore be compared to **tools placed into the hands of builders**. Possessing a tool does not make someone a skilled craftsman. An inexperienced builder may own excellent tools and still use them awkwardly, at the wrong time, or without understanding how his work relates to the structure being raised. Skill develops through growth, experience, correction, practice, and an increasing understanding of the building itself.

Paul describes himself in precisely this building context:

“According to the grace of God which was given to me, as a wise master builder I have laid the foundation, and another builds on it.”

— 1 Corinthians 3:10

Paul's description of himself as a wise master builder is not conceit. He immediately identifies the source of his capacity: “**according to the grace of God which was given to me.**” Grace had produced genuine skill. Paul had learned not merely to possess a ministry but to use what had been entrusted to him effectively for God's building.

This gives us an important distinction:

A gift gives us a tool; maturity teaches us how to build with it.

The mature question is therefore no longer merely, *Do I have something to contribute?* It becomes, *What does the building need from me?* Maturity learns what to supply, when to supply it, how much to supply, when to remain silent, when to yield to another member, and how one portion relates to the portions being supplied by others.

Gift provides capacity. **Maturity develops skill.**

The Grace That Saves Also Trains

Paul's reference to grace as the source of his skill opens another important dimension of spiritual growth. Grace must not be confined to the beginning of the Christian life. There is not one grace that saves and another grace that matures. There is **one grace of God**, yet Peter calls it "the manifold grace of God" (1 Pet. 4:10). The one divine grace is expressed and administered in manifold ways.

Titus makes this continuity especially clear:

"For the grace of God that brings salvation has appeared to all men, training us..."

— Titus 2:11–12

The grace that brings salvation is the grace that trains. Grace brings us into the life of Christ and then works within that life to educate, discipline, form, and mature us.

Paul expresses the same principle from his own experience:

"By the grace of God I am what I am, and His grace toward me was not in vain; but I labored more abundantly than they all, yet not I, but the grace of God which was with me."

— 1 Corinthians 15:10

Grace did not eliminate Paul's labor. Grace empowered it. Nor did Paul's labor replace grace. He could labor abundantly while recognizing that the effective power operating through that labor was the grace of God.

This explains why Paul could appeal to the Corinthians as those "working together with Him" not to "receive the grace of God in vain" (2 Cor. 6:1). Divine grace and human cooperation are not competitors. Grace supplies what we cannot originate from ourselves, while maturity includes learning to cooperate faithfully with what grace supplies.

Grace does not merely forgive the inexperienced builder; grace trains the builder.

Paul could therefore become a wise master builder without taking credit for the Source of his wisdom. His maturity was evidence not that he had moved beyond grace, but that grace had been allowed to work deeply and effectively within him.

Every Believer Has Received

This brings us to a question that is sometimes answered far too narrowly: **Are all believers gifted?**

The New Testament does not appear to recognize a class of gifted believers surrounded by believers who possess nothing to contribute. Paul says, “to each one of us grace was given according to the measure of Christ’s gift” (Eph. 4:7), while Peter writes, “as each one has received a gift, minister it to one another, as good stewards of the manifold grace of God” (1 Pet. 4:10). In that sense, **every believer is charismatic**: every member has received something of the one manifold grace of God to steward for others.

This does not mean that everyone possesses the same gift or measure. The very language of *measure* and *manifold grace* preserves diversity. What is universal is not sameness of function but **participation**. No member of Christ’s Body is intended to exist merely as a spectator.

Peter immediately gathers this manifold expression under two broad activities: **speaking and serving**. Some of God’s grace reaches His people through utterance; some reaches them through service. The person who speaks is to speak from God, and the person who serves is to serve from the strength God supplies. In either case, the member is stewarding something that originated in God for the benefit of others.

This changes the question from “**Am I gifted?**” to “**What measure of Christ’s gift has been entrusted to me, and am I learning to steward it for His Body?**”

Stewards in the House

Peter’s choice of the word translated “**stewards**” makes this even more significant. The Greek word is *oikonomos*. It belongs to the vocabulary of the household. An *oikonomos* is a steward or household manager—someone entrusted with administering what belongs to another.

The steward is not the owner.

God owns the House. God supplies the grace. The believer receives something from that grace and becomes responsible for administering what has been entrusted to him for others.

The gift, therefore, is not private property. **It is an entrusted portion of God’s manifold grace to be administered for the benefit of His household.**

Paul uses the same word when he writes:

“Let a man so consider us, as servants of Christ and stewards of the mysteries of God. Moreover it is required in stewards that one be found faithful.”

— 1 Corinthians 4:1–2

Stewardship introduces responsibility into gifting. The question is no longer simply whether I possess something genuine from God. The question becomes whether I am faithfully administering what belongs to Him.

Peter makes the corporate setting explicit: “minister it **to one another.**”

An *oikonomos* makes sense in the context of an *oikos*. A household steward is not an isolated possessor living independently from the house whose resources he administers. His stewardship exists because there is a household and because he has been entrusted with responsibility toward others within it.

This gives us another important distinction:

A gift can be possessed individually, but it fulfills its stewardship corporately.

The Body is the context of growth; **the House is the context of stewardship.**

The Body emphasizes organic relationship, joining, nourishment, and supply. The House emphasizes building, entrusted responsibility, administration, and stewardship. These images should not be collapsed into one another, but together they show why isolated Christianity falls short of the New Testament picture. Isolation deprives growth of its Body context and stewardship of its House context.

Grace gives. The believer receives. The House provides the relational context. The steward administers. Other members receive supply. **The House is built.**

Corinth: Tools Without Sufficient Skill

This helps us understand Corinth more sympathetically and more precisely. Their gifts were genuine. Paul does not solve their problems by denying their spiritual manifestations. Instead, he teaches them how those manifestations must operate if they are to build.

Throughout 1 Corinthians 12–14, Paul continually moves the discussion away from possession toward edification. The issue is not merely whether a manifestation is real, but whether its exercise benefits the assembly.

This is where maturity becomes crucial. A person may genuinely possess a spiritual tool and still require considerable growth in learning how to use it. The speaker must learn when speaking will edify and when silence will serve better. The one with a revelation must learn to yield when another receives something. The members must learn to be conduits for the manifestations of the Spirit and not think of themselves as more important in the gathering.

The Corinthians needed more than gifts.

They needed to become **skillful builders**.

Unlike Philippians, Paul's Corinthian correspondence does not identify a recognized company of elders or overseers. Silence cannot establish that none existed, and we should not ask it to prove more than it can. Yet the absence is noteworthy alongside Paul's explicit assessment of their spiritual condition.

Near the conclusion of 1 Corinthians, however, Paul draws attention to the household of Stephanas, who had "devoted themselves to the ministry of the saints," and urges the Corinthians to submit themselves "to such, and to everyone who works and labors with us" (1 Cor. 16:15–16).

His attention falls upon **demonstrated service rather than title**. Responsibility is becoming recognizable through proven life and labor among the saints.

This helps prepare us for Ephesus, where the relationship between maturity, responsibility, and shepherding becomes much clearer.

The Elders at Ephesus

As Paul travels toward Jerusalem, he stops at Miletus and sends to Ephesus for "the elders of the *ekklesia*" (Acts 20:17). When they arrive, Paul tells these same men:

"Take heed to yourselves and to all the flock, among which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to shepherd the *ekklesia* of God..."

— Acts 20:28

The language deserves careful attention. The men Paul summoned were elders. Those elders had been made overseers by the Holy Spirit, and those same men were charged to shepherd the flock.

These are not three separate offices. They are related aspects combined in the same individuals. **Elder** speaks of maturity; **oversight** describes their function

and responsibility; **shepherding** describes the gifting through which they feed, lead, guard, and care for the flock.

Peter presents the same relationship when he writes, “The elders who are among you I exhort, I who am a fellow elder,” and then instructs them to “shepherd the flock of God which is among you, serving as overseers” (1 Pet. 5:1–2). Elder, oversight, and shepherding again converge in the same people.

Peter’s self-description is especially instructive. He was unquestionably an apostle, yet when addressing those responsible for shepherding the flock, he identifies himself as **a fellow elder**. His apostolic gifting did not require him to present himself as a governmental level above them.

Peter was also a married man. Jesus healed his mother-in-law (Matt. 8:14–15), and Paul later refers to Cephas as taking along a believing wife (1 Cor. 9:5). This is consistent with the qualification that an overseer be “the husband of one wife” (1 Tim. 3:2; cf. Titus 1:6).

Paul, by contrast, is repeatedly identified as a slave of Christ, apostle, herald, and teacher, but the New Testament never identifies him as an elder. Scripture does not explain that distinction, so neither should we go beyond what it states.

What the evidence does allow us to see is that eldership cannot simply be another name for prominence or gifting. Paul was unquestionably mature and profoundly gifted. **Eldership joins maturity to a recognized responsibility for the local flock.**

The difference between Corinth and Ephesus therefore becomes instructive. Gift may appear early; responsibility for others requires proven maturity. The possession of spiritual tools does not automatically make someone a master builder.

Antioch and Gifted Coordination

If Ephesus gives us a clear picture of continuing local care, Antioch shows how gifted ministry could move beyond a locality without becoming detached from local life.

Acts 13 opens by identifying prophets and teachers “in the *ekklesia* that was at Antioch” (Acts 13:1). Barnabas, Simeon called Niger, Lucius of Cyrene, Manaen, and Saul are named. Luke does not introduce them as independent ministries operating alongside the assembly. **Their gifts are functioning within it.**

As they minister to the Lord and fast, the Holy Spirit says, “Now separate to Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them” (Acts 13:2). The initiative does not originate with Barnabas and Saul. They do not appoint themselves or independently announce a new sphere of ministry. The call originates with the Holy Spirit in the midst of gifted people already functioning together.

The others respond by fasting, praying, laying hands upon them, and sending them away. Luke immediately describes Barnabas and Saul as “being sent out by the Holy Spirit” (Acts 13:4). There is no conflict between these statements. The skilled brothers participate in recognizing and confirming what the Holy Spirit has initiated.

As the work unfolds, Luke explicitly refers to Barnabas and Paul as apostles (Acts 14:14). When that journey is completed, they return to Antioch, “where they had been commended to the grace of God for the work which they had completed.” They gather the *ekklesia* and report what God had done through them (Acts 14:26–27).

Antioch therefore gives us a significant picture of gifted coordination. The Holy Spirit initiates the call, spiritually responsible people recognize it, the workers are released, and their ministry extends beyond the locality. Yet the widening of their sphere does not erase their relationship to the assembly from which they were sent.

This is quite different from self-appointed ministry. Apostolic work emerges here from **calling, recognition, sending, and relationship**.

Once again, gift operates in context.

Local Responsibility and Translocal Ministry

Acts allows us to distinguish between a person’s local context and the sphere in which a gift may function. The prophets and teachers at Antioch initially appear serving within the local *ekklesia*. Barnabas and Saul are then released into work extending through other cities and regions. Their gifting has a translocal reach.

Eldership carries a different responsibility. Peter tells the elders to shepherd “the flock of God which is among you” (1 Pet. 5:2). Paul similarly tells the Ephesian elders to watch over the flock among whom the Holy Spirit had made them overseers (Acts 20:28). The language places their responsibility among a recognizable people.

This does not mean that elders have no relationship with believers beyond their locality, nor that prophets, teachers, evangelists, or apostles have no local context.

The distinction concerns **responsibility and sphere**. All gifted people function somewhere, but not every gift is limited to the place in which that person ordinarily lives.

Paul's years in Ephesus illustrate this balance particularly well. His ministry in that city produced effects extending far beyond it. Luke records that during this period "all who dwelt in Asia heard the word of the Lord Jesus" (Acts 19:10). Ephesus had become a center from which ministry radiated throughout a wider region.

Yet when Paul later addressed the continuing care of the *ekklesia* in Ephesus, he called the elders.

His ministry reached a region; their responsibility remained with the local flock.

The distinction is subtle but important. A wider sphere of service does not necessarily create a higher level of government. Trans-local workers may establish, equip, strengthen, and serve assemblies without displacing the mature people entrusted with continuing care in those localities.

A Developing Pattern in Acts

Jerusalem, Antioch, and Ephesus provide three particularly useful windows into the development of the *ekklesia* in Acts. Luke never identifies these cities as formal stages, so the pattern should not be pressed beyond the narrative. Nevertheless, there is a discernible development in the way corporate life and ministry function.

Jerusalem gives us the assembly in its formative period. The apostles occupy a prominent place as a rapidly growing body of believers learns corporate life and responds to new practical and spiritual demands. Even the dispute concerning Gentile believers eventually brings apostles and elders together at Jerusalem for consideration (Acts 15:2, 6).

At Antioch the picture has developed. We encounter prophets and teachers ministering together within an established local assembly. They are sufficiently coordinated and responsive to the Holy Spirit to recognize His call upon Barnabas and Saul and release them into a work extending beyond their own city.

Ephesus reveals a further dimension. Paul can labor from one strategic locality while the word spreads throughout Asia, yet established elders remain responsible for the local flock. Regional influence and local oversight coexist without becoming the same function.

Seen together, the three cities suggest a movement from corporate formation, through coordinated sending, toward a mature relationship between local care and ministry extending beyond the locality. It is not necessary to make Jerusalem, Antioch, and Ephesus into rigid stages to recognize that Acts is showing us an *ekklesia* learning to function with increasing breadth.

Gifts Given for the Building

This background helps us approach Ephesians 4 without converting Paul's language into a hierarchy of offices. Christ "gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some shepherds and teachers" for the equipping of the saints and the building up of His Body (Eph. 4:11–12).

The fivefold ministry are not given to replace the function of the saints. **They are given to equip the saints to function.**

Acts has already shown us some of these gifts in operation. Prophets and teachers function together at Antioch. Apostolic ministry moves across localities. At Ephesus, mature elders exercise oversight by shepherding the flock. These functions are real, but their reality does not depend upon arranging them into a ladder of rank.

The emphasis in Ephesians is upon what Christ gives for the growth of His Body. Ascension gifts equip and serve. Eldership is maturity in those entrusted with local care. Oversight carries responsibility for the flock, while shepherding supplies the feeding and leading necessary for that care. These are three in one. One is a gift of ministry in the fivefold ministry. One is maturity in Christ. One is the function of watching over the saints. These elders in Ephesus were gifted, mature, and responsible. Not three offices.

This also allows translocal ministry to retain its proper breadth. Apostles, prophets, evangelists, and teachers may serve beyond their own locality as the Holy Spirit opens a sphere for their work, while still having a local context themselves. Their wider usefulness does not make them detached from the ordinary life of the *ekklesia*, nor does it automatically place them over the elders responsible for another locality.

The resulting picture is not one of independence but **interdependence**. Local assemblies need not become isolated units, and translocal ministries need not become supervisory structures above them. Gifted people can move, serve, equip, and strengthen while local responsibility remains recognizable.

And the purpose remains building.

Learning to Function

If every believer has received a measure, then an ordered assembly must provide room for developing function.

Paul's instruction in 1 Corinthians 14 is striking:

“Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others judge. But if anything is revealed to another who sits by, let the first keep silent.”

— 1 Corinthians 14:29–30

The instruction assumes both function and restraint. A person may genuinely have something to contribute and still need to yield. Spirituality is not demonstrated merely by speaking; sometimes maturity is revealed by knowing when to stop.

Paul appears willing to accept the slower work of formation because people learn to function by functioning. His words only a verse later make this possibility remarkably broad: “For you can all prophesy one by one, so that everyone may learn and everyone may be encouraged” (1 Cor. 14:31).

Paul does not establish a rule that every believer must speak in every gathering. His language expresses possibility within an ordered assembly: all may function, but they do so **“one by one,”** and the purpose remains the good of the others—that everyone may learn and everyone may be encouraged. The opportunity to function is therefore broad, while the exercise of that opportunity remains governed by order, discernment, and edification.

But what should we understand by *prophesy*? The word can easily suggest a particular religious form of speech—a solemn “Thus says the Lord,” or primarily a prediction concerning something yet to happen. Scripture gives us a much richer picture of prophetic expression. The Psalms provide one of its most beautiful demonstrations. Peter identifies David as a prophet and interprets his words in Psalm 16 concerning Christ prophetically (Acts 2:25–31). Yet the Psalms contain far more than predictions. Their prophetic voice flows through songs, prayers, poetry, praise, testimony, lament, proclamation, remembrance, and declarations of the works and character of God.

This breadth helps illuminate Paul's statement, “you can all prophesy.” Prophetic expression need not be reduced to one manner of speaking. Paul himself describes its effect as “edification and exhortation and comfort” (1 Cor. 14:3). Whatever its particular form, it brings something that builds up, stirs up, and encourages the people of God. A prayer may carry such a portion. A song may give expression to something the Spirit is emphasizing among the saints. A poetic expression may

awaken spiritual perception. A testimony may strengthen faith. A Scripture brought with fresh understanding may exhort or comfort the gathering. The Psalms show how remarkably varied spiritual expression can be while remaining centered upon God and His purposes.

Seen this way, “you can all prophesy” opens something much richer than permission for everyone to deliver the same kind of religious speech. It points toward an assembly in which the Spirit may find expression through the varied measures and capacities of the saints. Creativity is the Spirit’s work of **building up the Body**. Yet when the saints are free to bring what the Spirit has genuinely worked within them, edification itself may take wonderfully varied forms.

Such freedom necessarily includes growth. A newer believer may not express something as clearly as a mature teacher. Someone may speak longer than necessary. Another may hesitate so much that the gathering becomes momentarily awkward. Someone may sincerely believe he has understood something from the Lord and later discover that his understanding needs adjustment.

Growth includes such moments.

The responsibility of mature saints is not to celebrate every mistake as though discernment were unnecessary. It is to create an environment in which mistakes can be corrected **without destroying the willingness of the saints to function**.

This is another place where the distinction between gift and maturity becomes invaluable. The inexperienced builder learns through building. Mature saints do not take the tools away from developing believers because their first attempts are imperfect. Neither do they allow careless work to continue without adjustment. They teach, encourage, correct, demonstrate, and make room for growth.

That is how builders are formed.

The Supply of Every Joint

Ephesians 4 shows us where this process is going.

Christ gives apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds and teachers for the equipping of the saints, “for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the Body of Christ” (Eph. 4:11–12).

When the apostle Paul describes the purpose of gifted leaders for mending the spiritual bones of the saints for the work of service, the Greek text reveals that leaders are not hired to perform every act of ministry themselves. Instead, their

role is foundational and supporting. They function as trainers, repairers, and outfitters, using their spiritual gifts to mend what is broken, set dislocated members back into proper alignment, and supply the necessary tools for spiritual labor.

The primary weight of the actual work of ministry rests squarely on the shoulders of the believers. The saints themselves are the active workforce in the field, called to carry out acts of service, care for one another, and advance the message of God in their daily spheres of influence.

Paul continues until he reaches the picture of a mature Body:

“from whom the whole body joined and fit together and compacted by that which every joint supplies, according to the effective working in the measure of every part, making the growth of the body to the building up of itself in love.”

— Ephesians 4:16 TKB

The distinction in Paul’s language is significant. Every joint supplies, while every part has an effective working according to its measure. A joint exists where members are joined. The picture is therefore not merely of individual believers possessing something independently and bringing it to a gathering. As members are joined to one another, their shared experience of Christ creates a relationship through which life can pass from one to another. **The connection itself becomes a place of nourishment to the Body.**

This brings another dimension to mature assembly life. A brother or sister may possess a genuine portion of Christ individually, but years of praying together, suffering together, learning together, correcting one another, bearing one another’s weaknesses, and sharing the experience of Christ deepen the joining of the members. What Christ has worked into one becomes available to another through the relationship that has formed between them. The joint supplies because the members are no longer functioning merely alongside one another; they have been joined in a common life and have learned to share that life together.

At the same time, every part has its own measure and its own working. This does not require everyone to do the same thing, possess the same measure, speak for the same amount of time, or exercise the same gift. God has placed the members as He pleased, and their different measures become effective as they operate in relationship with one another.

Those who are strong help those who are weak. Those who have walked longer help those who are beginning. Those who are beginning discover that the life of Christ within them also carries a portion for the Body. Gifts equip rather than

replace the saints, while mature believers nurture rather than dominate developing function.

Through it all, the Holy Spirit remains the Source, distributing as He wills. God sets the members as He pleases, Christ joins them together, every joint becomes a place of nourishment, and every part has an effective working according to its measure. The result is not merely a gathering in which many people participate, but a Body that grows through the life flowing within its own relationships.

The purpose of the gathering is to cultivate an environment in which the grace of God within the saints can be expressed through speaking and serving, resulting in the building up of the Body of Christ.

The question with which we come together gradually changes. Alongside *What will I receive today?* comes a growing awareness of what Christ has given and worked into us, what He has developed between us, and whether someone among His people may need that portion.

Perhaps the clearest evidence that an assembly is maturing, then, is not that its gatherings become increasingly impressive, but that its members are increasingly joined, increasingly responsive to one another, and increasingly capable of building one another up in love.

This is where Paul's thought finally brings us: the gifted ones equip the saints, the joints supply, every part operates in its measure, and **the Body makes the growth of the Body to the building up of itself in love.**

The goal is a Body joined together in Christ, where every joint supplies, every part has an effective working in its measure, and the Body builds itself up in love as Christ finds expression through them all.

Not One Roof

The recognition of one *ekklesia* in a locality does not require every believer in a city to gather continually beneath one physical roof. As the number of believers increased, gatherings could occur in different settings while remaining expressions of the same Body of Christ.

God is looking for **a coordinated life and responsibility within a given city.**

Different gatherings may exist, and different gifts may serve among them. Workers whose ministry extends beyond the locality may come and go. None of this requires those gatherings to develop separate identities around the people who serve them.

This brings us back to the simplicity with which Paul addressed Philippi: “all the saints in Christ Jesus who are in Philippi, with the overseers and deacons.”

The saints are the *ekklesia*. Mature people carry responsibility among them. Servants meet practical needs. Gifted people equip the Body, and some may be sent beyond the locality as the Holy Spirit directs. Each function contributes something necessary without needing to become the identity around which the assembly is organized.

Such order does not diminish spiritual gifts; it gives them room to serve their intended purpose. Neither does it diminish oversight; it locates that responsibility among mature people caring for an actual flock. Locality provides a practical sphere, while trans-local ministry keeps assemblies from becoming isolated from the wider movement of Christ’s Body.

What emerges is not an organization held together by rank, nor a collection of independent ministries pursuing separate visions. It is a people learning to function together under the Headship of Christ, with the Holy Spirit distributing gifts, developing maturity, recognizing responsibility, and directing service according to the needs of His Body.

The question is therefore not who occupies the highest position, but whether the order among us actually serves what Christ said He is building:

“My *ekklesia*.”

Order Produced by the Spirit

The pattern we have traced through Philippi, Corinth, Ephesus, and Antioch should not be mistaken for an organizational blueprint to be mechanically reproduced. The evidence itself points in another direction.

At Ephesus, Paul tells the elders that “the Holy Spirit has made you overseers” of the flock of God (Acts 20:28). The verb translated “made” is *tithēmi*, a word carrying the basic sense of putting, placing, setting, or appointing. The important point in Acts 20 is not merely the position into which these men were placed, but **the One doing the placing: the Holy Spirit**. Their responsibility among the flock is presented as something effected by the Spirit rather than merely conferred by human organization.

Antioch reveals the same sovereignty in another sphere. The Holy Spirit speaks in the midst of prophets and teachers, separates Barnabas and Saul for the work to which He has called them, and sends them forth (Acts 13:1–4).

Paul describes the functioning of the Body in the same way. There are “diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit,” “differences of ministries, but the same Lord,” and “diversities of operations, but it is the same God who works all in all” (1 Cor. 12:4–6). The manifestations of the Spirit are then distributed to each one individually “as He wills” (12:11).

The Spirit places, calls, sends, distributes, and operates according to His own will.

Divine order therefore begins in divine sovereignty.

This distinction is essential. We can imitate the outward arrangement of something God once produced without possessing the life that produced it. The New Testament pattern is valuable, therefore, not because it gives us an ecclesiastical mechanism to reproduce, but because it allows us to recognize the kind of order the Holy Spirit produces when His sovereignty is honored.

Maturity becomes recognizable. Gifts find their proper function. Responsibility develops among those whose life and labor demonstrate care for the saints. Workers are raised up and sent as the Spirit directs. Developing members are given room to learn. Mature members know how to supply and how to yield. Grace is received and faithfully stewarded. The resulting order is **spiritual before it is organizational and organic before it is institutional**.

Because the Spirit produces the order, organic order does not require every assembly to look identical. John saw seven assemblies in Asia represented as seven golden lampstands (Rev. 1:11–12, 20). They shared the same symbolic character as golden lampstands, yet each possessed its own condition, strengths, weaknesses, challenges, and testimony. Ephesus was not Smyrna; Smyrna was not Pergamum; Philadelphia was not Laodicea. Christ did not erase their distinctiveness. He addressed each assembly according to what was actually present there.

There is therefore a profound difference between **oneness of nature and sameness of expression**.

The life is one. The Head is one. The Spirit is one. The Body is one. Yet the expression of that life may take on a distinctive character in each locality as Christ is expressed among an actual people in an actual place.

Unity is not sameness or uniformity; it is unity within diversity.

This is one of the recognizable characteristics of the new creation. The members of the Body do not surrender their distinctions in order to become one; their distinctions are brought into the service of the one Body. Paul’s very language holds these realities together: diversities, yet the same Spirit; differences, yet the

same Lord; diversities of operations, yet the same God working all in all (1 Cor. 12:4–6). The Body is one precisely while its members are many (12:12–20).

Diversity, therefore, is not necessarily a threat to divine order. When it proceeds from the Spirit, it is an expression of His sovereign working within the one Body.

This also helps us understand how the New Testament pattern should be approached. We may learn from what the apostles established, recognize the principles revealed in their practice, and refuse arrangements that contradict the nature of the Body. But the living reality cannot finally be produced merely by following a pattern.

A lampstand cannot be made golden by copying the shape of another lampstand.

What must be common is the life, nature, Headship, and Spirit from which the expression proceeds. The same Spirit may then produce a genuine expression of Christ in each locality without requiring every locality to become a replica of another.

Grace supplies the gift. Growth develops the steward. Maturity develops skill. The House provides the sphere of stewardship. The Body provides the relationships of supply. The Holy Spirit governs the whole.

Our responsibility is to recognize and cooperate with the Holy Spirit as He produces, in His own sovereign and living way, the maturity, function, responsibility, and order necessary for what Christ said He is building:

“My ekklesia.”

Chapter 4

When the Saints Come Together

Possessing, Supplying, and Building One Another

Chapter Three considered the order that develops within the assembly as the Holy Spirit places responsibility, distributes gifts, and directs service according to His own will. But order raises another question. Once the saints gather, how are they meant to function together?

Corinth gives us an especially important place to begin because the assembly there was not mature. Paul had already told them, “I could not speak to you as to spiritual people but as to fleshly, as to babes in Christ” (1 Cor. 3:1). Yet these same believers came short in no spiritual gift (1:7). They possessed genuine spiritual capacity while still requiring considerable growth in the way they exercised it.

Paul's response is instructive. Throughout 1 Corinthians 12–14, he teaches these developing believers to exercise what they have received under the government of the Spirit, with love, discernment, order, and edification governing how they function. His attention continually returns to the divine Source from whom genuine spiritual function proceeds.

There are “diversities of gifts, but the same Spirit,” “differences of ministries, but the same Lord,” and “diversities of operations, but it is the same God who works all in all” (1 Cor. 12:4–6). The manifestation of the Spirit is given “to each one for the profit of all” (12:7), and the one Spirit distributes to each member individually “as He wills” (12:11).

The Source is divine. The distribution is sovereign. The purpose is corporate.

This becomes foundational for understanding what Paul later says about the gathering.

“Each of You Has”

Paul writes:

“Whenever you come together, each of you has a psalm, has a teaching, has a tongue, has a revelation, has an interpretation. Let all things be done for edification.”

— 1 Corinthians 14:26

The expression “each of you has” deserves careful attention.

Paul does not picture the saints arriving merely as an audience waiting for someone else to provide everything necessary for their spiritual needs. He assumes that something has been received among the members. One has a psalm. Another has a teaching. Another has something revealed or some other Spirit-given portion that may contribute to the gathering.

There is a possessive quality to Paul's language: **each of you has**.

This does not mean that spiritual things become our private possessions. Rather, what God gives must increasingly become inwardly real to us. His Word is received, pondered, believed, experienced, and worked into our lives until what has been given to us can become a rich source to build up someone else.

This places a beautiful responsibility upon every saint.

We should learn to take possession of the spiritual things God gives us.

A Scripture may become living during the week. A particular experience of Christ may strengthen our faith. Something in prayer may deepen our understanding. A song may rise within us. We may receive encouragement through a difficulty that later becomes encouragement for someone else. What begins between the Lord and one member may eventually be a blessing to the Body of Christ.

Paul therefore gives the saints something greater than permission to participate. He teaches them to live in such a relationship with Christ that when they come together, they may have something to bring.

The gathering then begins to take on a different character. I no longer come only asking, *What will I receive?* I can also come with another question:

What has the Lord given me that may help someone else?

Chapter Three established that each believer has received something of God's manifold grace to steward for others. Here that principle becomes practical. What has been received personally is capable of becoming corporate supply. The portion is not given merely for the possessor; it is entrusted so that, in the proper time and measure, it may benefit the household and supply the Body.

The Purpose Is Edification

Paul immediately protects "each of you has" from becoming individual display:

"Let all things be done for edification."

Building is the goal.

What I bring should supply something useful to the saints.

Earlier in the same chapter Paul describes what prophesying accomplishes: "But he that prophesies speaks to people for building up, and exhortation, and comfort" (1 Cor. 14:3 TKB). Or, in simpler language, **to build up, stir up, and cheer up the saints**. Paul continues, "he that prophesies builds up the Assembly" (14:4). His emphasis upon prophesying is consistently connected with building.

Earlier in the same letter Paul had warned, "Let each one take heed how he builds," describing materials of gold, silver, and precious stones (1 Cor. 3:10–12). Proverbs gives this building imagery a beautiful practical application: "Through wisdom a house is built, and by understanding it is established; by knowledge the rooms are filled with all precious and pleasant riches" (Prov. 24:3–4).

This gives us a practical picture of what prophesying by the Spirit can accomplish when the saints come together. **Wisdom builds. Understanding establishes. Knowledge fills the house with precious riches.** When the saints speak by the Spirit and bring wisdom, open understanding, or communicate a knowledge of Christ that strengthens others, something substantial is being added to God's building.

Prophesying is measured by what it contributes to the assembly. Does it build up? Does it stir up? Does it cheer up? Paul's concern is that through the speaking of the saints the ekklesia is built.

This changes our motivation for speaking.

I do not bring something to share merely because it interests me. I begin to consider the people around me. Who needs strengthening? Who may be discouraged? What is the Spirit emphasizing among us? Is what I am about to contribute appropriate to the present need of the Body?

Hebrews expresses the same orientation:

“Let us consider one another in order to stir up love and good works, not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together.”

— Hebrews 10:24–25

Before Hebrews speaks of assembling, it says, “consider one another.” That is profoundly pastoral. We gather not merely conscious of ourselves but increasingly conscious of one another.

This is why love stands at the center of Paul's treatment of spiritual manifestations. First Corinthians 13 is not an interruption between chapters 12 and 14. It reveals the inward way in which spiritual capacity must operate. Gifts may be genuine and impressive, yet without love their exercise can fail to accomplish the purpose for which they were given.

Love turns the attention of the gifted member away from self-expression and toward the condition of the others. It asks not simply, *Can I speak?* but *Will this strengthen them?* Not simply, *Have I received something?* but *How can what I have received serve the Body?*

Edification therefore gives spiritual freedom its direction. The Spirit supplies the life, the members possess differing measures, love governs their attitude, and building determines the usefulness of what is expressed.

Different Measures, One Body

“Each of you has” does not mean that every believer possesses the same measure of maturity or carries the same responsibility.

Paul’s own description of the Body makes such uniformity impossible. God has set the members in the Body “just as He pleased” (1 Cor. 12:18). The eye is not the hand. The head is not the feet. The members differ, yet precisely through those differences they contribute to one Body.

The same is true of spiritual maturity.

A believer who has recently come to Christ and someone who has walked with Him for many years may sit in the same gathering. They possess the same Christ, but they do not necessarily possess the same experience of Christ. They share the same life, but that life has not reached the same measure of development in each one.

A mature assembly is one in which different measures of maturity are increasingly able to function together under one Head.

The newer believer should not conclude, “I have nothing because I do not have what that seasoned brother or sister has.” Neither should the seasoned believer conclude, “Because I have more experience, I should provide and equip everything and do everything in the church.”

Both conclusions misunderstand the Body.

The younger believer must be encouraged to recognize and exercise the measure that has genuinely been given. The seasoned believer has a different responsibility: not merely to supply from greater experience, but to help others learn how to function and be useful to the saints.

Maturity should make room for growth.

Learning to Function

There is something wonderfully patient in Paul’s treatment of Corinth. These believers were immature, their gatherings were not always orderly, and spiritual manifestations could be exercised without sufficient consideration for others. Yet Paul does not respond by creating a system designed to make mistakes impossible.

He remains committed to their growth. His correction teaches them how to exercise what the Spirit has given with love, discernment, restraint, and concern for the edification of others. He tells speakers when to speak and when to remain silent,

limits certain contributions, requires interpretation where necessary, and reminds them that “the spirits of the prophets are subject to the prophets” (1 Cor. 14:32). These instructions establish spiritual boundaries without replacing the functioning of the members with a method that functions for them.

Paul’s instruction is remarkably practical:

“Let two or three prophets speak and let the others judge. But if anything is revealed to another who sits by, let the first keep silent.”

— 1 Corinthians 14:29–30

The instruction assumes both function and restraint. A person may genuinely have something to contribute and still need to yield. Spirituality is not demonstrated merely by speaking; sometimes maturity is revealed by knowing when to stop.

This is important because mutual participation is not the same as taking turns. Paul is describing a gathering responsive enough for one member to speak, another to discern, and the first to yield when the Spirit supplies something through someone else. Mature function therefore includes sensitivity not only to what I carry, but to what Christ may be supplying through another member.

Paul appears willing to accept the slower work of formation because people learn to function by functioning. His words only a verse later make this possibility remarkably broad: “For you can all prophesy one by one, so that everyone may learn and everyone may be encouraged” (1 Cor. 14:31). Paul does not establish a rule that every believer must speak in every gathering. His language expresses possibility within an ordered assembly: all may function, but they do so “one by one,” and the purpose remains the good of the others—that everyone may learn and everyone may be encouraged. The opportunity to function is therefore broad, while the exercise of that opportunity remains governed by order, discernment, and edification.

But what should we understand by *prophesy*? The word can easily suggest a particular religious form of speech—a solemn “Thus says the Lord,” or primarily a prediction concerning something yet to happen. Scripture gives us a much richer picture of prophetic expression. The Psalms provide one of its most beautiful demonstrations. Peter identifies David as a prophet and interprets his words in Psalm 16 concerning Christ prophetically (Acts 2:25–31). Yet the Psalms contain far more than predictions. Their prophetic voice flows through songs, prayers, poetry, praise, testimony, lament, proclamation, remembrance, and declarations of the works and character of God.

This breadth helps illuminate Paul's statement, "you can all prophesy." Prophetic expression need not be reduced to one manner of speaking. Paul himself describes its effect as "edification and exhortation and comfort" (1 Cor. 14:3). Whatever its particular form, it brings something that builds up, stirs up, and encourages the people of God. A prayer may carry such a portion. A song may give expression to something the Spirit is emphasizing among the saints. A poetic expression may awaken spiritual perception. A testimony may strengthen faith. A Scripture brought with fresh understanding may exhort or comfort the gathering. The Psalms show how remarkably varied spiritual expression can be while remaining centered upon God and His purposes.

Seen this way, "you can all prophesy" opens something much richer than permission for everyone to deliver the same kind of religious speech. It points toward an assembly in which the Spirit may find expression through the varied measures and capacities of the saints. Creativity is the Spirit's work **of building up the Body**. Yet when the saints are free to bring what the Spirit has genuinely worked within them, edification itself may take wonderfully varied forms.

Such freedom necessarily includes growth. A newer believer may not express something as clearly as a mature teacher. Someone may speak longer than necessary. Another may hesitate so much that the gathering becomes momentarily awkward. Someone may sincerely believe he has understood something from the Lord and later discover that his understanding needs adjustment.

Growth inevitably involves missteps.

Maturity does not mean ignoring errors or discarding discernment. Rather, it means cultivating a safe space where mistakes can be corrected without discouraging believers from stepping forward to function.

Paul gives us a remarkable balance elsewhere:

"Do not quench the Spirit. Do not despise prophecies. Test all things; hold fast what is good."

— 1 Thessalonians 5:19–21

The balance is significant. Paul will not protect the saints from error by quenching spiritual expression, nor will he protect spiritual expression from examination. What is expressed is to be tested, and what proves good is to be held fast. Spiritual freedom and spiritual discernment therefore belong together.

The Patience of Maturity

This requires patience, particularly from those who are more mature.

Experience can create a subtle temptation. A seasoned believer may know how to make a gathering work. He knows how to fill an awkward silence, redirect a weak contribution, provide a teaching, move the gathering forward, and prevent uncertainty.

Sometimes that experience is genuinely needed.

But maturity must also know when not to intervene.

Human management can produce outward efficiency much faster than spiritual growth can produce inward capacity. The danger is that we may successfully make the gathering work while unintentionally preventing the saints from learning to function.

There is a difference between helping the Body develop and functioning in place of the Body.

A child provides a simple picture. A baby already possesses an internal structure, but that structure must develop with the life. Bones strengthen, muscles grow, balance develops, and coordination increases until the child can carry its own weight, stand, walk, speak, and increasingly function without being carried.

No wise parent looks at an infant and demands that it immediately perform what its undeveloped body cannot yet sustain. Neither does the parent conclude that because the child may fall, the child should never attempt to walk. The parent holds when holding is needed, steadies when support is needed, catches when there is danger, and also allows the child to wobble while balance and coordination are developing. The structure necessary for mature function develops with the life.

The same patience is necessary in the assembly. We must never demand from younger saints a level of function for which they have not yet been inwardly formed. But neither should we continually carry them because carrying them is easier, quicker, or more orderly.

The goal is growth.

Life Developing into Function

This helps us distinguish spiritual order from externally imposed control.

Organic life is not without structure. The human body is extraordinarily ordered. But its mature structure develops together with its life.

Paul's Body metaphor therefore gives us more than a picture of unity. It gives us a picture of living coordination.

God has "set the members, each one of them, in the body just as He pleased" (1 Cor. 12:18). Each member develops its capacity to function in relationship with the others. The result is not independence but coordination.

This is why mature believers must resist the temptation simply to "make it work."

If we see what the assembly could become, we may attempt to produce externally what has not yet developed internally. The result may appear orderly, but outward order by itself is not evidence of mature Body life.

Mature spiritual care requires something more difficult: confidence in the Holy Spirit's ability to develop the people in whom He dwells. Patience, in this sense, becomes an expression of faith. Mature saints nurture the life, encourage growth, correct what genuinely needs correction, and guard the assembly from what would harm it, while still giving developing members room to discover their measure, exercise their gifts, make mistakes, receive adjustment, and grow. Their responsibility is to help the saints mature until the Body increasingly functions according to the life already within it.

Mature saints therefore do more than function well themselves. They help create conditions in which others can become functional. They encourage without flattering, correct without crushing, discern without controlling, and demonstrate without replacing. Their maturity makes room for the maturity of others.

"Each of You Has" Does Not Mean "Each Must Speak"

There is another distinction that protects the gathering from becoming a new method.

Paul says, "each of you has." He does not say that every member must speak during every gathering.

If we turn every-member function into a requirement that everyone contribute audibly each time the saints gather, we have simply replaced one meeting method with another.

The same Spirit who gives something must remain sovereign over its expression.

Sometimes what I possess is precisely what the Body needs and should be supplied; at another time another member may carry the needed portion, and maturity recognizes the value of remaining quiet. Something received from the

Lord may belong to another occasion, and there are moments when attentive listening is itself the appropriate response. Restraint is therefore not the opposite of function. It can be evidence of maturity.

The governing question remains:

What will build the Body?

The Word Dwelling Richly Among the Saints

As the saints mature, something beautiful becomes possible.

Paul writes to the Colossians:

“Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom, teaching and admonishing one another.”

— Colossians 3:16

The Word is not merely being delivered to the saints. It is dwelling richly in them.

Because it dwells within them, they increasingly become capable of teaching and admonishing one another.

This is what spiritual possession ultimately produces. What has been received becomes inwardly established, and what has become inwardly established can become profitable for the growth of others.

The gathering therefore becomes richer as the saints themselves become richer in Christ.

The seasoned believer brings years of experience, testing, learning, correction, suffering, and knowing the Lord. The younger believer brings the freshness of what Christ is presently revealing and working within him. Different measures do not have to compete. They can enhance the flavor of the Spirit’s work in one another.

Unity does not require sameness.

The Body needs the measure of every member.

A More Mature Level of Functioning

If Corinth shows us an immature but genuinely gifted assembly learning how to function, Paul’s letters also give us glimpses of what that functioning can become as the saints themselves mature. The difference is not that mature believers

eventually graduate from mutual participation into a more controlled form of gathering. The development is inward. The saints become increasingly filled with the Spirit, richly inhabited by the Word, capable of strengthening one another, and sensitive enough to know both when to speak and when to yield.

Ephesians describes this mature inward condition:

“Be filled with the Spirit, speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody in your heart to the Lord, giving thanks always for all things to God the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, submitting to one another in the fear of Christ.”

— Ephesians 5:18–21

The order of Paul’s thought is important. He begins not with an instruction about how to conduct a gathering but with a condition: “Be filled with the Spirit.” From that fullness come speaking to one another, singing, inward melody to the Lord, thanksgiving, and mutual submission. The actions proceed from an inward source.

Colossians presents a closely related picture from another side:

“Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly in all wisdom, teaching and admonishing one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with grace in your hearts to the Lord.”

— Colossians 3:16

Ephesians emphasizes being filled with the Spirit; Colossians emphasizes the Word of Christ dwelling richly within. Both lead to mutual edification. The saints are not merely hearing the Word; the Word has taken up residence within them richly enough that they can teach and admonish one another. They are not merely receiving spiritual ministry; they are becoming spiritually capable of ministering Christ to each other.

Romans gives us another striking indication of this developed capacity. Paul tells the believers there:

“I myself am confident concerning you, my brethren, that you also are full of goodness, filled with all knowledge, able also to admonish one another.”

— Romans 15:14

Paul expresses confidence that something has matured within the saints themselves. They are becoming able to care for and strengthen one another. This is

a highly functioning level of Body life: saints who have themselves grown sufficiently to carry spiritual responsibility toward one another.

Romans also tells the strong to bear with the weaknesses of those without strength rather than merely please themselves (Rom. 15:1). Mature capacity therefore becomes responsibility. Strength is not given so that the strong may dominate the gathering; it enables them to bear, receive, encourage, and help others toward maturity.

The attitudes accompanying this maturity are as important as the actions. A seasoned saint may possess much, yet being filled with the Spirit does not make that person insistent. Ephesians joins spiritual fullness to thanksgiving and mutual submission. Mature believers learn not only how to give but how to receive; not only how to speak but how to listen; not only how to recognize what they carry but how to recognize Christ ministering through another member.

This makes mutual submission particularly important. “Each of you has” must never become “I must be heard.” The mature member does not regard a spiritual portion as a claim upon the gathering. What has been received is held for the good of the Body. If another member is contributing what is needed, maturity can yield. If a younger believer is beginning to function, maturity can make room. If something needs adjustment, maturity can respond without crushing the developing member. Spiritual fullness produces not self-importance but increasing sensitivity to Christ and to His Body.

Seen together, these passages give us a beautiful picture of developed assembly life: **Spirit-filled, Word-filled, thankful, mutually submissive saints who have become capable of teaching, admonishing, encouraging, receiving, yielding, and supplying one another.** The gathering becomes more fruitful as the abundance of Christ within the saints finds expression among them.

This is not uniformity. Different members still carry different measures, histories, gifts, and experiences. But maturity enables those differences to work together for the good of the Body rather than compete with one another. The seasoned saints do not need to dominate the gathering in order to protect it. Their greater maturity can become the very means by which others are encouraged to function, discernment deepens, and the whole Body becomes increasingly responsive to the Spirit.

The Supply of Every Joint

Ephesians 4 shows us where this process is going.

Christ gives apostles, prophets, evangelists, shepherds and teachers for the equipping of the saints, “for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the Body of Christ” (Eph. 4:11–12).

The fivefold ministries are given to develop the saints for their own work of ministry and the building up of the Body.

Paul continues until he reaches the picture of a mature Body:

“from whom the whole body joined and fit together and compacted by that which every joint supplies, according to the effective working in the measure of every part, making the growth of the body to the building up of itself in love.”

— Ephesians 4:16 TKB

The distinction in Paul’s language is significant. Every joint supplies, while every part has an effective working according to its measure. A joint exists where members are joined. The picture is therefore not merely of individual believers possessing something independently and bringing it to a gathering. As members are joined to one another, their shared experience of Christ creates a relationship through which life can pass from one to another. **The connection itself becomes a place of nourishment to the Body.**

This brings another dimension to mature assembly life. A brother or sister may possess a genuine portion of Christ individually, but years of praying together, suffering together, learning together, correcting one another, bearing one another’s weaknesses, and sharing the experience of Christ deepen the joining of the members. What Christ has worked into one becomes available to another through the relationship that has formed between them. The joint supplies because the members are no longer functioning merely alongside one another; they have been joined in a common life and have learned to share that life together.

At the same time, every part has its own measure and its own working. This does not require everyone to do the same thing, possess the same measure, speak for the same amount of time, or exercise the same gift. God has placed the members as He pleased, and their different measures become effective as they operate in relationship with one another.

Those who are strong help those who are weak. Those who have walked longer help those who are beginning. Those who are beginning discover that the life of Christ within them also carries a portion for the Body. Gifts equip rather than replace the saints, while mature believers nurture rather than dominate developing function.

Through it all, the Holy Spirit remains the Source, distributing as He wills. God sets the members as He pleases, Christ joins them together, every joint becomes a place of nourishment, and every part has an effective working according to its measure. The result is not merely a gathering in which many people participate, but a Body that grows through the life flowing within its own relationships.

When the Saints Come Together

The purpose of the gathering, then, is not to create an opportunity for everyone to speak, nor is it to produce a perfectly managed meeting. It is to cultivate an environment in which the life of Christ within His people can flow through the relationships He has formed among them for the building up of His Body.

The question with which we come together gradually changes. Alongside *What will I receive today?* comes a growing awareness of what Christ has given and worked into us, what He has developed between us, and whether someone among His people may need that portion.

This does not make preparation unnecessary. A teaching may have been carefully studied, a song may have been written beforehand, a Scripture may have occupied someone's heart for days, or a testimony may have developed through a long experience with God. The issue is not spontaneity versus preparation. The issue is whether what we bring has become a living supply for the building of others and whether we remain sensitive to the Spirit and to the other members while bringing it.

Nor does mutual function eliminate leadership. Mature saints remain responsible to discern, protect, shepherd, and help maintain an environment in which the saints can function safely and profitably. But leadership reaches its healthiest expression when it does not gather all function into itself. It uses maturity to release, develop, coordinate, and protect the function of the Body.

Perhaps the clearest evidence that an assembly is maturing, then, is not that its gatherings become increasingly impressive, but that its members are increasingly joined, increasingly responsive to one another, and increasingly capable of building one another up in love.

This is where Paul's thought finally brings us: the saints come possessing, what they possess becomes supply, supply is governed by love and edification, developing members learn to function, mature members learn both to supply and to yield, relationships deepen into joints, every part works according to its measure, and the Body makes the growth of the Body to the building up of itself in love.

The goal is not a meeting in which everyone speaks. The goal is a Body joined together in Christ, where every joint supplies, every part has an effective working in its measure, and the Body builds itself up in love as Christ finds expression through them all.

Chapter Five

Why Christ Builds His Assembly

When Jesus first announced His ekklesia, He did not simply say that He would gather people who believed in Him. He said, **“I will build My ekklesia, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it”** (Matt. 16:18). His choice of words is significant. The verb *oikodomeō* carries the ordinary sense of building or constructing and belongs to the language of house-building. Jesus was not merely gathering stones. **He was constructing something with them.**

Peter later develops precisely this picture. Believers are “living stones” who are “being built up a spiritual house” (1 Pet. 2:5). A pile of stones is not a house. Every stone in the pile may be genuine, valuable, and alive, but proximity is not building. The stones must be fitted and joined together before the house takes form. Paul describes the same reality when he sees the saints “being built together for a dwelling place of God in spirit” (Eph. 2:22).

This helps us understand why the functioning of the saints considered in the previous chapter is so essential. Paul’s emphasis upon prophesying for edification is not participation for participation’s sake. The one who prophesies speaks for “edification and exhortation and comfort”—to **build up, stir up, and cheer up** (1 Cor. 14:3). His governing instruction for the gathering is, “Let all things be done for edification” (14:26). Through a song, a prayer, a testimony, a Scripture opened with spiritual understanding, or another Spirit-given portion, the members strengthen, encourage, and enrich one another. Christ is the Builder, yet He carries out His work through the operation of His Spirit within His members.

What we have considered as the functioning of the assembly is therefore directly related to Christ’s declaration, “I will build My ekklesia.”

But why does God want a House? Why does Christ want a Body? Why does the Father desire sons and daughters?

These questions take us beyond meetings to the purpose of the assembly itself.

A Body Makes Him Visible

A body makes an otherwise invisible life visible. If we were spirits without bodies, the inward person could not be seen. Through the body, however, the person within becomes perceptible. A body manifests **presence**. It expresses character, carries out intention, provides contact with others, and enables the life within to act in the world.

Paul's description of the assembly as the Body of Christ therefore carries profound significance. Christ is not merely forming an organization that represents Him. Through His Body, His otherwise invisible life finds tangible manifestation. His compassion can reach someone through the hands of a member. His encouragement can be heard through another's words. His love becomes perceptible through relationships. The intention of the Head finds practical operation through the members.

Paul's first encounter with the risen Jesus revealed how real this identification is.

Saul had been persecuting those who followed Jesus when a voice from heaven asked, **"Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting Me?"** His immediate response was, **"Who are You, Lord?"** The answer came, **"I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting"** (Acts 9:4–5).

Saul was hurting people on earth, yet Jesus received what was being done to them as something being done to Himself. In effect, Christ was revealing: **I am the One you are hurting when you are oppressing My people.**

This was not merely a metaphor for solidarity. Saul encountered a spiritual reality. The risen Christ was livingly identified with His members on earth. Years later Paul would write, "For as the body is one and has many members ... so also is Christ" (1 Cor. 12:12).

Jesus expressed the same identification concerning those who belong to His family: **"Inasmuch as you did it to one of the least of these My brothers, you did it to Me"** (Matt. 25:40 TKB). These are not brothers merely in the generic sense of fellow human beings, but those who belong to Him as members of His family. What touches them, He receives as touching Himself.

The Body, then, does more than represent an absent Christ. It manifests the presence of the living Christ. This is why its practical condition matters so deeply. What is occurring among the members can either clarify or obscure the One whose life they share.

The Place God Chose

The Old Covenant provides a remarkable shadow of this corporate purpose.

In Deuteronomy 12, Israel was repeatedly instructed to seek the place Yahweh would choose to put His name. They were specifically warned against doing whatever was right in their own eyes (Deut. 12:5, 8, 11, 13–14). Worship was not left to individual preference. God determined the place associated with His dwelling and His name.

Eventually that place was Jerusalem. Significantly, the boundary was a **city**—not a country, province, tribe, or independently chosen religious center. Within that city the House was established.

At the height of Israel’s kingdom, several remarkable things converged: the chosen city, the House of God, the son of David, rest from enemies, divine wisdom, and a witness that reached beyond Israel.

Solomon could say, **“Yahweh my God has given me rest on every side”** (1 Kings 5:4). Upon that ground he built the House for God’s name. The wisdom given to the son of David then became known throughout the surrounding world. Kings heard of it, and the Queen of Sheba came to Jerusalem to see for herself.

What she encountered is especially significant. She did not merely hear Solomon answer difficult questions. She saw his wisdom embodied in the order of his house and kingdom—the house he had built, the seating of his servants, the attendance of his ministers, their clothing, and the ordered life surrounding the king (1 Kings 10:1–9). **Wisdom had become visible in what had been established.**

This provides a remarkable shadow of Paul’s declaration that through the ekklesia “the manifold wisdom of God” is being made known to rulers and authorities in the heavenly places (Eph. 3:10). This is not a lexical identification but a typological correspondence. Under Solomon, the wisdom associated with the son of David and God’s House became known before rulers. In the New Covenant reality, divine wisdom is displayed through the assembly.

God’s wisdom is therefore not merely something His people teach. It can be seen in what He forms among them. People of different histories, measures, personalities, and abilities become one Body. Every joint supplies and every part operates according to its measure. Members learn to honor, forgive, receive, and care for one another. What human wisdom could not produce becomes a demonstration of the wisdom of God.

When Another Kingdom Must Be Preserved

Paul teaches us to read Israel’s history as more than history. The things that happened to them “became our examples” and were written “for our admonition” (1 Cor. 10:6, 11). We therefore look at Israel not to place the assembly under the Old

Covenant, but to observe in the shadow patterns that instruct and warn God's people. Jeroboam provides the sobering contrast.

After the kingdom divided, he feared that if the people continued going to Jerusalem to worship, "the heart of this people will turn back to their lord, Rehoboam king of Judah" (1 Kings 12:27). The place God had chosen now threatened the kingdom Jeroboam wanted to preserve.

His solution was to establish alternative centers at Bethel and Dan. He instituted another priesthood and another feast; one the text says he had "devised in his own heart" (1 Kings 12:33).

His motive deserves careful attention. **He changed the ground of worship in order to preserve his own kingdom.**

What had become divided politically was now given a divided religious form. Maintaining a separate kingdom required maintaining separate centers.

Division and idolatry soon became inseparable. The calves at Bethel and Dan were visible idols, but before the images were made there was already something Jeroboam was determined to retain. Paul later describes covetousness as idolatry (Col. 3:5). Idolatry, therefore, cannot be restricted to bowing before a physical image. Something we desire, possess, or feel compelled to protect can assume a place that belongs to God.

Jeroboam feared that obedience to God's chosen place would cost him what he wanted to keep. Another center therefore became necessary to preserve it.

Throughout Israel's later history, high places multiplied on hills and under green trees. At some Yahweh was invoked; at others Baal and foreign gods were worshiped. Competing centers brought mixture, division, and idolatry, while Israel's enemies repeatedly gained power to oppress the people of God.

The contrast with Solomon is striking. Under Solomon, the House stood in the chosen city, there was rest on every side, and the wisdom of the son of David became known among the nations. Under Jeroboam, a divided kingdom received competing centers of worship, and division became joined to idolatry.

What appears historically in the shadow is later exposed morally in the New Testament. Paul places **idolatry, selfish ambitions, dissensions, and factions** among the works of the flesh and warns that those who practice such things will not inherit the kingdom of God (Gal. 5:19–21).

The lesson is not that every disagreement constitutes Jeroboam's sin, nor that every organizational distinction can simply be labeled idolatry. The warning reaches deeper. When preserving a separate interest requires maintaining a separate identity at the expense of the oneness God has established, the flesh has begun producing precisely the kind of division the New Testament condemns.

A ministry, movement, tradition, reputation, following, or sphere of influence does not have to begin as something evil to become something we eventually feel compelled to protect. When maintaining what is **ours** becomes more important than the good of the whole Body, Jeroboam's history deserves our attention.

Who Will Reign?

Beneath the issue of ground lies an even deeper question: **Who will reign over God's people?**

When Israel demanded a king "like all the nations," Yahweh told Samuel, **"They have not rejected you, but they have rejected Me, that I should not reign over them"** (1 Sam. 8:7).

Israel wanted a man like the nations had. Yet hidden within God's purpose was something far greater. God Himself would become Man. **"The Word became flesh"** (John 1:14). The King they ultimately needed would not be a man independent of God, but God manifested in humanity.

Jesus takes up that ancient rejection of divine government in His parable: **"We will not have this man to reign over us"** (Luke 19:14). The issue exposed in Samuel's day had reached its climactic expression. The One Israel had rejected as King had come among them as Man.

The question remained: **Who will reign?**

Jeroboam shows how closely place and government are related. Jerusalem threatened his authority, so another religious arrangement was required to sustain his separate kingdom. Changing the place eventually revealed whose interests were governing the people.

God's chosen ground protects God's chosen government.

The New Covenant answer is not another centralized human administration. Christ Himself is the Head of His Body. His authority is heavenly, yet His life and direction are livingly present within His members through the Spirit. The Head is not an absentee ruler requiring an earthly headquarters to take His place.

A City Within the City

Here the Old Covenant shadow undergoes a profound transformation.

Under the former arrangement, the tribes traveled toward one earthly city containing a centralized sanctuary. In the New Covenant, the people themselves become God's dwelling. They are living stones forming a spiritual House, "being built together for a dwelling place of God in spirit" (Eph. 2:22).

Yet the city remains a recognizable practical boundary in the apostolic record. There is the assembly of God in Corinth, the assembly in Ephesus, and the assembly of the Thessalonians. The universal reality of the one Body finds tangible local form within actual earthly cities.

Revelation carries the universal picture to its fullness. John is told, **"Come, I will show you the bride, the Lamb's wife,"** and he sees **"the holy city, Jerusalem"** (Rev. 21:9–10). The New Jerusalem is not merely a destination to which God's people travel. In the vision, the City itself is the Bride, the Lamb's wife—a transformed corporate people.

There is no separate temple within her, for God and the Lamb are her temple. The Lamb is her light, and the throne of God and of the Lamb is in her (Rev. 21:22–23; 22:3).

In the Old Covenant, God's people went to the city where He had placed His name. **In the New Covenant reality, God's people themselves become the City bearing His presence.**

The universal ekklesia is portrayed in this City-Bride reality, while the local assembly becomes a microcosm of that universal reality within an earthly city. Within the human city is another corporate reality—a people joined to one Christ and sharing one Life. In this sense, there is **a city of God within the earthly city.**

The dwelling has become decentralized, but Christ has not. There remains one Head, one Foundation, one Spirit, and one Body. The Head is in the heavens, yet through the Spirit His government is inwardly operative within His members. The Christ who is objectively the one Foundation is also subjectively present within the people established upon Him.

The **city** provides the practical ground. The **human spirit** provides the spiritual ground. **Christ alone is the Foundation.**

Upon this ground, the saints are not merely assembled. They are built.

A Life Hades Cannot Overcome

We can now return to Jesus' original announcement:

“I will build My ekklesia, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”

The promise is attached to **what Christ builds**.

Jesus does not promise merely that Christianity will survive or that individual believers will continue to exist. His words concern the ekklesia He Himself is constructing. The Life within His people is being brought into corporate form, and against that built assembly He declares that the gates of Hades will not prevail.

Toward Hades, the assembly manifests **a Life death cannot overcome**.

Toward the world, it manifests **a Christ the world cannot otherwise see**.

That the World May Believe

Jesus prayed:

“that they also may be one in Us, that the world may believe that You sent Me” (John 17:21).

He then continued:

“I in them, and You in Me, that they may be made perfect in one, and that the world may know that You have sent Me” (John 17:23).

The world cannot directly observe the spiritual reality that believers have been made one in Christ. It can, however, see how those believers treat one another.

It sees love or hostility, peace or contention, mutual honor or rivalry, forgiveness or retaliation, reconciliation or separation. The oneness secured in Christ receives practical form through the relationships of His people.

This is why certain works of the flesh become especially serious matters of testimony.

Within Paul's larger catalogue in Galatians 5 is a striking cluster bearing directly upon relationships: **hatred, contentions, jealousies, outbursts of wrath, selfish ambitions, dissensions, and factions** (Gal. 5:19–21). Whether Paul intended significance in the number itself need not be pressed; their collective effect is unmistakable.

These manifestations do not remain hidden when practiced. They become visible between people.

Hatred affects how another member is treated. Jealousy colors our response to another's blessing or recognition. Contention brings conflict openly into relationships. Wrath makes hostility audible and observable. Selfish ambition introduces competition. Dissension produces separation. Faction gives that separation an identifiable party or camp.

The flesh therefore does not merely defile individuals. **Some of its works disfigure the corporate testimony.**

They make something else visible precisely where Christ intended His own character to be seen. The world may never examine our doctrine concerning the one Body, but it can observe whether that confession has affected the way we live with one another.

Paul then adds the solemn warning that those who **practice** such things “will not inherit the kingdom of God” (Gal. 5:21). The issue is not an isolated failure or an honest difference. Paul addresses an ongoing practice of what proceeds from the flesh. The way believers conduct their relationships therefore touches not only present testimony but the serious matter of kingdom inheritance.

The Test of Disagreement

How we handle disagreement is one of the clearest tests of spiritual maturity.

Corinth demonstrates this vividly. Paul tells them that he could not speak to them as spiritual people but “as to babes in Christ,” and among the evidences he gives are envy, strife, and divisions (1 Cor. 3:1–3).

Their immaturity was not demonstrated merely by having different opinions. Mature believers can disagree. Their condition became evident in **what their disagreements became.**

A difference does not have to become contention. Contention does not have to become a quarrel. A quarrel does not have to produce separation, and separation does not have to harden into faction.

When the flesh governs the response, however, the question can subtly shift from **What is right?** to **Who is right?** Pride becomes invested in a position. Winning becomes more important than understanding. Someone who is a member of Christ gradually becomes an opponent who must be defeated.

A principle worth remembering is:

It is not who is right, but what is right.

Mature saints can listen, reconsider, receive correction, acknowledge what another sees, and even remain in disagreement without permitting that difference to define their relationship. Maturity is not demonstrated by never differing. **It is revealed in how we handle our differences.**

Perhaps one of the clearest demonstrations of oneness is therefore not that believers agree about everything, but that when they genuinely disagree, **Christ remains greater between them than the issue that differs between them.**

Greater Light Is an Invitation to Realignment

None of this requires us to question the sincerity, devotion, or love for Christ found among believers meeting in independent groups or denominational settings. Many divisions have been inherited rather than deliberately created, and sincere believers may simply be practicing according to the measure of light they have received. The issue is not to condemn those believers, but to ask whether our present practice fully corresponds to the revelation of the one Body.

If division weakens the practical testimony of Christ, remaining divided cannot make us stronger. It should not surprise us if the assembly has sometimes appeared less effective corporately than the picture given by our Lord. Jesus connected His building with the remarkable promise that “the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it,” and He connected the practiced oneness of His people with a witness “that the world may believe.”

Recognizing that our practice has fallen short of that revelation need not become an occasion for judgment. **Greater light is an invitation to realignment.**

If something has weakened the practical oneness of the Body, moving toward that oneness can only strengthen us. If competing identities have obscured what believers already share in Christ, allowing those identities to become secondary to Him can make our common Life more apparent. The answer to division is not another movement organized against the movements that came before it. It is a renewed willingness to stand together upon what God has already established in Christ.

Such realignment does not require us to discard everything God has genuinely given through our different histories. Quite the opposite. It allows those riches to become available to the whole. What one member has learned can strengthen another. What one group has received need not remain the possession of that

group. The riches of Christ were never intended to become the private property of separate kingdoms.

Whatever measure of practical oneness Christ gains among His people strengthens what He is forming. Every wall that falls makes greater fellowship possible. Every competing identity that becomes secondary to Christ opens another relationship. Every reconciliation gives His Life another avenue through which to flow.

The purpose of greater light, therefore, is not to leave us looking backward with regret or outward with criticism, but forward with hope. Scripture does not reveal the House merely to show us where we have fallen short. It shows us what remains possible as Christ is given His rightful place among His people.

The Psalmist said, “**strength and beauty are in His sanctuary**” (Ps. 96:6).

In God’s House there is strength and beauty, and I want that in my life.

That desire changes the spirit in which we approach these truths. We are not searching Scripture for evidence that others are wrong. We are allowing its light to show us something more beautiful and asking why we would not want to move closer to it.

Realignment is not punishment for having seen imperfectly. It is the privilege that comes with greater light.

A Pattern to Guard and Reproduce

What was established in the first generation becomes a pattern to be guarded and reproduced in every generation that follows. The historical events Jesus said would occur within that generation reached their fulfillment, but His purpose in the ekklesia did not expire with them.

Every generation receives something it did not originate. Our responsibility is not to reinvent God’s intention according to the religious preferences of our time, but to embody faithfully what has been revealed: **one Christ, one Body, one Spirit, with the universal reality finding practical form among His people city by city as they are built together in spirit.**

This pattern possesses no power apart from Christ Himself. The city is not a formula, and the human spirit is not a technique. Our strength is the indwelling Life of the One who said, “**I will build My ekklesia.**” The ground simply keeps us from substituting something of human choosing for what belongs to Him.

Why, then, does Christ want a Body? So that His otherwise invisible Life may become perceptible and His presence manifested.

Why does God want a House? So that He may have a dwelling among His people.

Why does the Father desire sons and daughters? So that His Life and likeness may be expressed through a family belonging to Him.

The assembly is therefore about something far greater than successful gatherings. **The gatherings serve the building, and the building serves the purpose of God.**

Within earthly cities, Christ desires a people bearing His Life, displaying His manifold wisdom, living under His government, and practicing the oneness for which He prayed.

Toward the world, His people give something of **Christ to be seen.**

Toward rulers and authorities, the assembly displays **the manifold wisdom of God.**

And toward the gates of Hades, what Christ builds manifests **a Life they cannot overcome.**

This is why the pattern matters. This is why the ground matters. This is why the stones must become a House.

Christ is not merely gathering what belongs to Him. He is building with them a dwelling through which He can be known.

The assembly is part of the Father's environment for the formation of mature sons and daughters. Here we learn to receive and to supply, **to speak and to serve**, to exercise authority without controlling, to accept correction without fainting, to bear weakness without despising it, to steward what has been entrusted to us without becoming possessive, and to build something larger than ourselves.

These are not merely meeting skills. **They are the education of heirs.**

The Father's *paideia* produces "the peaceable fruit of righteousness" in those who have been trained by it (Heb. 12:11). And righteousness is not incidental to the Kingdom: "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of Your throne" (Ps. 89:14), while of the Son it is written, "A scepter of righteousness is the scepter of Your kingdom" (Heb. 1:8).

The heir who is already "lord of all" must therefore mature into the character appropriate to what he possesses. We are joint heirs with Christ, and those who endure reign with Him. **Enduring the training is preparation for reigning.**

We are not merely stones in the House. We are living stones being built who learn how to build. We are not merely recipients of grace. We are stewards of the manifold grace of God. We are not merely children awaiting an inheritance. We are heirs being matured into the responsible possession of what is already ours. We are God's building, yet Paul also calls us God's fellow workers.

We are being built in order to build. We are being trained in order to reign.

And perhaps this is where the entire matter of the assembly finally becomes larger than the assembly itself. Christ is not merely arranging meetings. He is building a House, forming a Body, maturing sons, developing heirs, training stewards, and producing fellow workers who can intelligently and responsibly cooperate with Him.

This is why we have skin in the game.

All things are ours. And we are Christ's.

We have something to possess.

We have something to steward.

We have something to build.

We have an inheritance into which we must mature.

And we have a King with whom we are called to reign.

What, then, have we seen?

We have seen something far greater than another way of doing church.

We have seen something of what Christ saw when He said, "I will build My ekklesia."